# What's A Better Thought?

## Finding Your Way from Troubling Thoughts to Peace of Mind and Joy

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October 2026

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Printing October 26, 2026

Published by
**Purple Hills Books**
San Jose, California, USA
http://purplehillsbooks.com/

ISBN:TBD

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This book is dedicated to my beloved husband, Jim, whose love filled my life with joy, laughter, and deep companionship for 60 years.

After Jim's death, when grief felt overwhelming, it was my dear friends and family who gently helped bring me back to life again. They called me, listened to me, checked on me, and cared about how I was doing. Their kindness, week after week, lifted my spirits more than they may ever know.

I am deeply grateful for their love and friendship.

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# I Invite You

You are warmly invited to spend a little time with a simple question:

**What's a better thought?**

It is not a complicated question, and it does not demand a perfect answer. It is simply a gentle way of turning our attention toward thoughts that bring a little more peace, hope, kindness, or encouragement.

As you read these pages, you may find yourself remembering good moments, noticing new possibilities, or discovering thoughts that help lighten your heart.

If that happens—even a little—then this book will have done what I hoped it might do.

# How to Use This Book

This book is not meant to be rushed through or studied like a textbook. It is meant to be a gentle companion.

You may read it from beginning to end, or simply open to any page that catches your interest. Each chapter offers ideas, reflections, and questions that may help you notice your thoughts and discover ones that feel kinder, wiser, or more hopeful.

You might pause sometimes and ask yourself the small question that inspired this book:

**What's a better thought?**

There is no single right answer. The better thought is simply the one that helps you feel a little more peaceful, a little more encouraged, or a little more able to enjoy the day.

Throughout the book, you will also find exercises, practices, and actions you can try. These are there for the times when you want to do more than think about an idea—you want to practice something that may help you create better thoughts in your everyday life. You can find these practical sections easily by looking under Exercises, Practices, and Action Steps in the index.

You do not have to do everything. Choose what interests you, try what seems useful, and return to a practice whenever you need it.

Take your time. Reflect if you wish. Smile when something rings true. And return to the question whenever you need it.

*(No tests will be given at the end.)*

# Introduction

My intention in writing this book is to share an idea that helped me move away from sadness, depression, and grief, and return to enjoying life again—with hope and appreciation for the good memories that are always there.

One of the most surprising discoveries of my life was realizing how much my thoughts were shaping the way I felt and what I did.

When I talk about *a better thought*, I'm talking about gently moving away from worry, sadness, rumination, anxiety, anger, and self-criticism—and choosing thoughts that help me feel calmer, happier, and more at peace.

A better thought can take many forms. It might be a memory of a wonderful time in your life, or of something you did that made you feel capable or proud.

It might be a thought about something pleasant you could do today, a spiritual thought that gives you comfort or perspective, or a question that leads you toward something interesting, meaningful, playful, or inspiring.

It might even be the beginning of a new memory you would like to make.

A better thought does not have to be profound. It only has to help your mind move in a kinder, more hopeful, or more life-giving direction.

**What would you rather be thinking?**

We all have moments when we suddenly notice:

*(Uh oh, my mind is not being very kind to me right now. It happens. Minds can be a bit dramatic.)*

That's the moment when this question becomes powerful:

**What's a better thought?**

That small question became a gentle guide, helping me turn my attention toward thoughts that brought comfort, strength, and even moments of happiness.

In this book, I explore the kinds of thoughts that can lift us up, the skills that help us shift our thinking, the reasons why better thoughts matter, and the obstacles that sometimes get in the way.

My hope is that this little question—*What's a better thought?*—might become a helpful companion for you as well.

# Chapter 1

# What's a Better Thought?

It happened in the middle of a Marriage Enrichment retreat.

There were about twenty couples there, divided into small groups of five couples each. Jim and I had been involved in Marriage Enrichment for forty years. We had taught it, led it, believed in it, and—most importantly—practiced it ourselves.

We didn't just tell other couples to listen to each other. We listened to each other. We didn't just teach communication exercises. We did them. Year after year, we worked on our own marriage along with the couples we were helping.

By then, after almost sixty years together, I thought our marriage was about as wonderful as a marriage could possibly be.

Well, almost.

There was still Jim's driving.

I never did learn to sit peacefully beside him. When I thought he was getting too close to something, I would gasp or stomp my foot on an imaginary brake pedal, and Jim would get irritated with me. After forty years of Marriage Enrichment, we had apparently solved everything except how Jim drove and how I reacted to it.

But otherwise, we had built something extraordinary together.

And now I was beginning to be afraid I was going to lose him.

## What If This Is Our Last Christmas?

It had begun in November 2015.

Jim was seventy-nine and becoming unusually tired. At first we didn't know what was wrong. Then the lymph nodes under his chin and along the side of his head began swelling. He seemed to be swelling up before my eyes.

He went to the doctor. Maybe it was mononucleosis, they thought. Could it be mumps? But Jim kept getting worse.

Christmas was approaching, and we had planned to drive from San Jose to our son's home in San Diego. Finally we told the family we didn't think we could make the trip. Dad wasn't feeling well enough, and the drive would be too much for him.

So they came to us instead.

I remember looking around at my family that Christmas and having a frightening thought:

**What if this is our last Christmas?**

I didn't know that it was.

But some part of me was already afraid.

By January, Jim still had not been diagnosed. We were the president couple of the Silicon Valley chapter of Better Marriages, and our annual retreat was coming up. Because Jim felt so poorly, we had already arranged for another couple to take over. We would attend, but we wouldn't lead one of the small groups.

Then, the day before the retreat, the new leader called us in tears. Another leadership couple had become ill and couldn't come.

She hated to ask us. She knew how Jim was feeling. But did we possibly want to take one of the groups?

Jim and I were both on the phone.

"We'll do it," he said.

So we did.

It took an enormous effort for him just to be there.

During one of our small-group sessions, a couple began talking about Christmas. Their daughter was getting married, and they realized this had been their last Christmas with their family exactly as it had always been.

Their last Christmas.

Something inside me broke.

I began crying quietly.

When it was time for another couple to have a dialogue, Jim looked at me with concern and said maybe we needed a turn.

And in front of that little circle of people, I told my husband what I had been terrified to say.

"I can't live without you."

I cried and cried.

I told him I didn't know what I would do if whatever was happening to him turned out to be serious.

Jim did what we had taught other people to do for decades.

He listened.

He didn't tell me not to be ridiculous. He didn't try to talk me out of being frightened. He active-listened to me and let me say what I was feeling.

The group listened too. They were wonderfully warm and caring.

Strangely, saying the horrible thing helped.

I had gotten it out of me. I had said aloud what I was most afraid of. And I think that helped me become more able to support Jim through what was coming.

I had no idea how much support he was going to need.

## Valiant and Scared

In February, Jim was finally diagnosed with CLL, chronic lymphocytic leukemia.

Then one day, after a blood test, the doctor told him to go to the hospital immediately.

That began the final three and a half months of his life.

We were mostly alone together during those months. His treatments weakened his immune system, and it was winter and flu season. We were afraid for him to be around many people.

So our world became very small.

There were doctors and hospitals and treatments. There was a port for his medicine, and when he wanted a shower we had to wrap his arm carefully in Saran Wrap to keep the water away from it. Getting him into the shower, getting everything protected, getting him washed and safely out again could take half the day.

And somehow we laughed.

There were strawberry milkshakes after doctors' appointments and treatments.

There were emails. I wrote to perhaps sixty people, telling them how Jim was doing. I tried to include something hopeful—some good day he had had, some encouraging possibility. And I asked people to send us jokes.

They did.

We needed those jokes.

We listened to music on our wonderful stereo. I would choose Beethoven. Jim might choose *Grand Canyon Suite*. We would listen and talk about what we loved in the music.

Sometimes I read him stories.

Once, when I took my car in for a smog check, I discovered that the man who ran the place had an immense, magnificent aquarium filled with marvelous fish.

I asked him, "Could I bring my husband here to see your fish?"

"Absolutely," he said.

So one day I brought Jim. He could barely walk far enough to get inside, but we made it. We looked at those amazing fish and even got to feed them.

In the middle of leukemia, we had an adventure at the smog-check station.

I didn't know it then, but I was already doing something I would spend years learning to do more deliberately.

I was looking for a better thought.

Or perhaps a better moment.

Not because the frightening things weren't real. They were terribly real.

There were nights in the emergency room when Jim couldn't stand or even sit any longer. Once, when there was no bed available, he stretched out on a hard bench with my coat underneath his head. I finally called Sandy and Russ and said, "Please. I need help."

They came.

They didn't fix anything. They were simply there with us.

When Jim was admitted to the hospital, I didn't want to leave him. Sometimes they gave me a reclining chair, but I discovered that I slept better in my car. I would go out to the hospital parking lot, where a security guard walked around during the night, find a place where I felt safe, and sleep there.

For a while my diet seemed to consist largely of Ensure and PowerBars.

When things were a little brighter, I would go down to the hospital cafeteria and find little goodies for the two of us.

And there were always those strawberry milkshakes.

We were valiant and scared.

Courageous and petrified.

Both were true.

## The Night Lynn Called

My friend Lynn called me often.

Most people wrote emails, or I called them. But Lynn called.

Sometimes she seemed to call at precisely the moment I needed her most.

One night I was sitting in my car while the doctors were giving Jim a new treatment. They had run out of good choices. They were going to try something different, but they couldn't tell us what would happen.

He might not survive the treatment.

He might die that night.

They had already told us to gather the family.

I sat in the car waiting and wondering whether my husband would be alive in the morning.

And Lynn called.

It was hard on her, too. Again and again she was the person who happened to call when another piece of terrible news had arrived.

But that night Jim didn't die.

In fact, he rallied.

For a little while in April, he became well enough to do some wonderfully ordinary things.

He got a haircut.

He went to the bank.

He got a pizza and had his best friend over.

I even went out to lunch with a friend, one of the first times I had left him socially since he became ill.

For a couple of days, life almost looked like life again.

Then he went down.

And this time he didn't come back.

## When His Heart Stopped

Jim died on a Thursday morning in the middle of May, at 9:40.

I was holding him.

He was unconscious. I had my arms wrapped around him and my head against his chest. I could hear his heart. I could hear him breathing.

His breathing became faster and faster.

So did his heart.

I kept talking to him.

I told him how much I loved him.

I told him how much I cared about him.

I told him what a wonderful man he had been and what a magnificent life I had had because of him.

And then I heard his heart stop.

I heard his last breath.

He was dead.

I was devastated.

And I was glad.

Glad for him.

The suffering was over.

That was one of the strangest things about those months and about grief afterward: completely opposite feelings could both be true.

I could be destroyed because Jim was dead and grateful that he no longer had to suffer.

I went home.

Our sons, Jim and Ken, came. Our daughter-in-law Gerrie came. The family gathered around me.

Mostly I stayed in bed.

Jim and I had talked about death before he became ill. He had told me that after he died, whatever I wanted was what he wanted.

"I won't be here," he had essentially said. "Do whatever makes you most comfortable."

He thought cremation made sense, if that was all right with me.

I couldn't bear the thought of a formal memorial service. I couldn't imagine waiting and then going through the agony all over again.

So I did something I could bear.

I invited people to our house.

They could come Saturday evening for wine and snacks or Sunday morning for coffee and doughnuts.

And they came.

They met my sons and Gerrie and my grandchildren. We were together. We remembered Jim.

At one of those gatherings, several friends asked me, "What can we do for you?"

I knew the answer.

"Call me. Write to me."

So Edna got organized.

Someone would call Sunday. Someone else Monday. Someone Tuesday and others the rest of the week

And they did it.

Faithfully.

Some of them kept calling for years.

## Maybe It Was Jim

Lynn had told me something else after Jim died.

"Watch," she said. "See if he contacts you somehow."

I didn't particularly believe that.

But I looked anyway.

A couple of days after Jim died, I went swimming in our pool. The Polaris pool cleaner had gotten stuck because something had wrapped around one of its wheels, and I was trying to untangle it.

A bee appeared.

It hovered around me and around the machine.

And it stayed.

And stayed.

I wasn't afraid of it.

Instead, I had the strangest, sweetest thought.

**Maybe that's Jim.**

Maybe he was coming to tell me I was going to be all right.

And maybe, knowing Jim, he was doing it in a slightly funny way.

I even called Gerrie to come look because the bee's behavior seemed so unusual.

A few days later, I opened my bedroom curtains in the morning and there was a bee right in the middle of the window screen.

It was still, just there.

When I came upstairs that afternoon for a nap, it was still there. This time it moved, cleaning its legs and face.

Then it flew away.

Was it Jim?

I don't know.

I didn't have to know.

**Maybe it was Jim,** was a much better thought than **Jim is completely gone forever.**

And for then, maybe was enough.

# "The Best Is Yet to Be"

A few weeks after Jim died, some of our Marriage Enrichment friends invited me to dinner at one of our favorite restaurants, the Cheesecake Factory.

I had already turned down one invitation to go out with a group.

Then I thought perhaps I should say yes to something.

So I went.

They were very sweet to me, and we actually had a lovely evening.

At one point we were talking about hope.

My friend Linda suddenly said, "And the best is yet to be."

I think perhaps she surprised herself.

She certainly surprised me.

Everything inside me wanted to shout:

**NO!**

How could the best possibly be yet to come?

The best had just died.

Nothing would ever be that good again.

Instead, I looked at her, probably looking agonized, and said something like:

"Oh . . . do you think?"

We hugged.

And that was all.

Except it wasn't all.

The sentence came home with me.

**The best is yet to be.**

I didn't believe it.

But a tiny question had entered my mind.

*Could there still be something good?*

Not best.

I couldn't imagine best.

But something?

Could there possibly be a real life after this?

I didn't know.

But I had begun to wonder.

## They Were Watching Me

My friends kept calling.

They took me to lunch and dinner. They asked how I was doing. They listened.

And gradually another thought occurred to me.

Many of these women were twenty or thirty years younger than I was. I had known some of them since their children were young, when I taught Parent Effectiveness Training. Others had known Jim and me through Marriage Enrichment.

And I began to wonder whether they were watching me for another reason.

Maybe they were afraid too.

Maybe somewhere inside themselves they were thinking, *Someday my husband could die. What would happen to me? Could I survive it?*

And now here I was.

A living demonstration.

I never asked them whether that was what they were thinking. I didn't need to.

It was a good thought.

**Maybe if I survive this, I can show them that they could survive it too.**

I had spent much of my adult life teaching.

Perhaps this was something else I was being asked to teach.

But first I had to survive it.

And there was something I hadn't told them.

For some time, I had been carrying another plan inside me.

Before Jim died, I had heard that sometimes when people had been married for many years and one of them died, the other died soon afterward.

I hoped that would happen to me.

It seemed comforting.

Perhaps I would simply die too.

And if I didn't—if life without Jim became as unbearable as I expected it to be—I had decided that I could end my own life.

At the time, that thought gave me relief.

Dying seemed like a better thought than living without Jim.

But I was still here.

And these women were watching me live.

## The Hours When Nobody Was There

I got all the help I could.

I went to a grief group.

I had a therapist at Kaiser.

A friend who had worked as a grief counselor let me tell the horrible story—the illness, the treatments, the despair, the suffering.

I cried.

I talked.

I let people help me.

All of that mattered enormously.

But eventually lunch ended.

The friend went home.

The telephone call ended.

The television went off.

And then there was just me and my mind.

My mind had discovered that it could replay the last months of Jim's life with astonishing clarity.

It could take me back to the hospital.

To the treatments.

To his suffering.

To the frightening nights.

To every moment when we had despaired.

Again and again and again.

And finally something occurred to me.

If my mind could take me back to the terrible things so vividly, couldn't it take me somewhere else?

Couldn't I choose another memory?

I found a scrap of paper.

And I wrote:

**What's a better thought?**

Then I looked for one.

And there was Jim.

Not sick.

Not in a hospital bed.

Not dying.

Jim was coming down our stairs.

## Jim in His Fedora

After retirement, Jim volunteered as a docent at the Computer History Museum, where one of his jobs was demonstrating the IBM 1401 computer.

Our son Jim suggested that his father ought to demonstrate it in costume.

"What kind of costume?" my husband asked.

Our son explained.

A white shirt.

A tie.

A three-piece suit.

His lace-up shoes.

In other words, dress exactly as a businessman might have dressed when the 1401 was new in 1959.

Jim thought this was a splendid idea.

So on Saturday mornings, he would get all dressed up to go demonstrate the computer.

I would be sitting on the couch, and when I saw him coming down the stairs, I would get up to admire him.

He looked gorgeous.

And I told him so.

Jim would become sheepish about being admired.

But he would let me do it.

Sometimes he would even button his jacket for me.

And then came the finishing touch.

His fedora.

With a little feather in it.

There he was.

My beautiful husband.

And for a moment, I wasn't in the hospital.

I wasn't listening to his heart stop.

I wasn't imagining the rest of my life without him.

I was at the bottom of our stairs, admiring the man I loved.

And I smiled.

Nothing had changed.

Jim was still dead.

But **I had changed what I was experiencing for that moment.**

So I tried another memory.

Jim swimming and swimming and swimming in our pool, then stopping his laps to dive down and inspect the black algae, attacking it with his pumice stone.

Another.

One of our romantic evenings together: champagne and lobster Thermidor—and afterward a Band-Aid for Jim's hand because the lobster had fought back.

I began collecting them.

Better thoughts.

Better memories.

Not because the terrible memories weren't true.

They were.

But the beautiful memories were true too.

Why should the worst three and a half months of our nearly sixty years together be allowed to occupy my mind while all those thousands of wonderful days waited quietly somewhere else?

I had stumbled onto something.

I didn't understand all of it yet.

I certainly didn't know that ten years later I would still be practicing it, deliberately recalling a wonderful memory every morning—memories not only of Jim, but of my whole life: people I have loved, things I have accomplished, adventures, peak experiences, ridiculous moments, beautiful moments, times when I was brave, times when I was useful, times when I was simply happy.

Back then, I only knew that I was suffering and that sometimes I could change what was happening inside me by asking one small question.

I had thought the better thought might be dying.

Then other people began lending me thoughts.

*Maybe Jim is still near.*

*Maybe these women need to see that I can survive.*

*Maybe there is still something good ahead.*

And finally I began learning how to find them for myself.

I could not change the fact that Jim had died.

I could not think my way out of grief.

I could not make those terrible three and a half months unhappen.

But perhaps I didn't have to let my mind live there all day.

I could choose, for this moment, to go somewhere else.

Back to the swimming pool.

Back to the music.

Back to the lobster Thermidor.

Back to the stairs.

There was Jim again, buttoning his jacket and putting on that wonderful fedora with the little feather because he knew I loved looking at him.

I could see him.

I could feel the love.

I could smile.

And then I could ask myself again:

**What's a better thought?**

# Chapter 2

## When the Mind Gets Stuck

After Jim died, I discovered that my mind could get stuck.

It could pick one terrible scene from the last months of his life and play it again.

And again.

And again.

I didn't have to invite the memory in. It knew how to find me all by itself.

it was something like the intrusive memories people describe with post traumatic stress: the mind returning to a painful moment even when you do not want it to

Eventually I began deliberately replacing some of those terrible scenes with other memories from our nearly sixty years together. That was the beginning of my question:

**What's a better thought?**

But grief didn't invent my tendency to get stuck in a thought.

I had been doing it all my life.

Perhaps you have too.

## The Thought That Won't Go Away

Sometimes something worries me and my mind seems to decide:

*This is important. We'd better keep thinking about it.*

Unfortunately, thinking about it for the 47th time doesn't necessarily accomplish anything that thinking about it the first 46 times failed to accomplish.

But my mind can be very persistent.

There is a word for some of this: **rumination**.

Researchers sometimes use the broader term **repetitive negative thinking** for negative thoughts that are intrusive, repetitive, and difficult to disengage from.

I think of it more simply.

**My mind is stuck.**

Something has captured my attention, and I keep circling it.

Sometimes the concern is legitimate.

Sometimes it is exaggerated.

Sometimes it is highly improbable.

And sometimes, when I finally get far enough away from it, I wonder:

*What in the world was I thinking?*

The difficulty is that while I am inside the thought, it can feel completely reasonable.

## I Was Going to Be Kidnapped

At one point in my life I became frightened that I might be kidnapped.

I don't remember everything that started it, but I remember that the possibility became very real in my mind.

I thought about it too much.

Finally I talked to my son.

He didn't give me a long lecture about anxiety. He didn't try to prove that nothing bad could ever happen to me.

He asked me a question.

Were people living in my retirement community being kidnapped?

Well.

No.

That was rather inconvenient for my kidnapping story.

His question made me step outside the story my mind had constructed and look at what was actually happening around me.

I was living among all these other people.

They weren't disappearing.

Nobody seemed particularly interested in kidnapping any of us.

Perhaps I had mistaken a **possible** event for a **probable** event.

Those are very different things.

And suddenly my frightening thought didn't seem quite so convincing.

My son had given me a better thought.

Or perhaps, more accurately, he had given me a **better question**.

## Go Outside and Look at Your House

Many years earlier, I had another fixation.

I became afraid our house was going to be robbed.

I worried enough about it that we eventually got a security system.

Then a friend gave me an interesting assignment.

"Go outside," my friend said.

So I did.

"Look at your house. Then look at the other houses in the neighborhood. What is there about your house that would make somebody particularly want to rob yours?"

That changed something.

Inside my head, I had been starring in a story called:

**Our House Is Going to Be Robbed.**

Outside on the street, I was simply looking at a house among other houses.

My friend had moved me from **imagination to observation**.

That has become one of the ways I think about better thoughts now.

Sometimes I don't need to manufacture a happier thought.

I need to **look at the evidence**.

What do I actually know?

What am I assuming?

Is this happening—or am I imagining that it might happen?

How likely is it?

What would I tell a friend who had exactly this worry?

A better thought isn't necessarily a cheerful thought.

Sometimes a better thought is simply a **truer thought**.

## The Day I Accidentally Blasted Myself Out of a Thought

One of my favorite experiences with a stuck mind happened completely by accident.

I was driving somewhere and worrying.

I can't even remember what I was worrying about now, which tells you something about the importance of the worry.

At the time, however, I was going over and over it.

I knew I was doing it.

*Stop thinking about this,* I probably told myself.

That didn't work.

So I decided to change the music. Maybe different music would help change my mood.

I reached for the control.

And I hit the wrong thing.

Instead of changing the music, I turned the volume up enormously.

**BLAST!**

The sound was terrific.

And suddenly—

**the thought was gone.**

Whatever I had been perseverating about had simply vanished from the center of my attention.

I had startled myself right out of it.

I remember being fascinated.

*Where did the thought go?*

The problem hadn't been solved.

I hadn't reasoned my way out of it.

Nobody had reassured me.

I hadn't found a brilliant piece of wisdom.

Something unexpected had simply interrupted the loop.

That experience stayed with me.

Apparently my attention was not as permanently attached to that thought as it had felt.

It could move.

## Can a Brain Get Into a Rut?

This makes me think of a wagon wheel traveling over the same dirt road again and again.

Eventually there are grooves, ruts.

Once the wheels fall into those grooves, that's the direction the wagon naturally wants to travel.

Our brains are vastly more complicated than a dirt road, of course. But I find the image useful.

Things we repeatedly think about can become familiar mental ruts or grooves.

Worry can become a rut.

Self-criticism can become a rut.

Replaying an argument can become a rut.

So can gratitude. A better groove. (*Groovy*!)

So can remembering someone we love.

So can looking for goodness.

The fascinating part for me is that the brain isn't simply a container holding thoughts. It is an active physical organ made up of interconnected networks. Scientists are still learning how these networks contribute to attention, emotion, memory, depression, anxiety, and our ability to shift from one mental state to another.

And recently I learned about something that made me think about my stuck thoughts in a completely new way.

## A Magnetic Nudge to the Brain

It is called **transcranial magnetic stimulation**, or **TMS**.

TMS is a genuine medical treatment, not a metaphor. A clinician places an electromagnetic coil against the head and delivers carefully controlled magnetic pulses. Those pulses induce small electrical currents that stimulate neurons and neural circuits in targeted areas of the brain.

A repeated form called rTMS is used clinically for certain conditions, particularly depression that has not responded adequately to other treatment. Researchers are continuing to investigate exactly how changing activity in interconnected brain networks can improve mood.

I find this astonishing.

Here is a person whose brain has become caught in patterns associated with serious depression. And physicians have developed a way of applying magnetic stimulation to particular areas of the brain and, for some people, helping those patterns change.

Now, I want to be very clear.

**Turning up my car radio was not TMS.**

And asking *What's a better thought?* is not a substitute for medical treatment for depression or another serious mental illness.

But learning about TMS gave me a wonderful image.

**The brain is not necessarily stuck forever just because it feels stuck right now.**

Something can change.

Awareness can begin.

A circuit can behave differently.

Attention can move.

The mind can find another track.

And for the ordinary stuck thoughts of everyday life, perhaps we have our own collection of small nudges available.

## Interrupt the Pattern

My deafening radio taught me something before I knew what to call it:

**Sometimes interrupting a thought is more useful than arguing with it.**

Change the music.

Stand up.

Walk outside.

Call someone.

Take a shower.

Look at something beautiful.

Say a prayer.

Read something funny.

Take ten slow breaths.

Go into another room.

Remember the man in the fedora.

None of these guarantees that the unwanted thought will disappear.

And sometimes a painful thought needs our attention. There may be a decision to make, a loss to grieve, a problem to solve, an apology to give, or help we need to seek.

But there is a difference between **thinking about a problem** and **circling a problem**.

One may lead somewhere.

The other keeps bringing me back to the same spot.

I'm trying to learn to notice the difference.

**Joe Dispenza**offers a wonderfully simple way of **interrupting an unwanted pattern of thought.** In his book Breaking the Habit of Being Yourself, he suggests that when we catch ourselves falling into a limiting thought, feeling, or behavior, we say the word **"Change!"** out loud.

I like the idea of making the interruption definite enough for the brain to notice. **"Change!"** can stop the familiar train of thought for a moment. Then I can add my own question:

What's a better thought?

The first word interrupts the old pathway. The question opens the door to another one.

## Is This Thought Helping Me?

I've discovered that I can ask myself several questions from Byron Kady when my mind gets stuck:

**Is this thought true?**

**How do I know?**

**Is it probable, or merely possible?**

**Am I solving something—or just going around again?**

**Is there anything I can actually do about this right now?**

And finally:

**What's a better thought?**

Sometimes the answer is a happier thought.

Sometimes it's a more realistic thought.

Sometimes it's a funny thought.

Sometimes it is simply:

*I have thought about this enough for now.*

That can be a very good thought.

## The Fly on the Masterpiece

I once came across an image from Marc and Angel that stayed with me.

Imagine that an enormous, magnificent work of art is hanging in front of you—beautiful colors, wonderful textures, extraordinary detail.

And then a little dark fly lands on it.

Where do you look?

At the fly.

Of course you notice the fly. Our minds are very good at noticing what is wrong.

But why spend the next twenty minutes staring at it?

That's the part I'm interested in.

Life contains flies.

It contains disappointments, mistakes, frightening possibilities, irritating people, physical discomfort, embarrassing memories and red lights when we're already late.

I'm not advocating pretending that the fly isn't there.

I'm asking:

**Do I want to spend all afternoon looking at it?**

## The Story I Am Telling Myself

There is another piece of this that fascinates me.

We are storytellers.

Something happens, and almost immediately we begin explaining it to ourselves.

Someone doesn't answer my message.

*She's angry with me.*

I wake up feeling tired.

*This whole day is going to be awful.*

Someone I love sounds irritated.

*I've done something wrong.*

Something could conceivably happen.

*It's going to happen.*

Notice what has occurred.

A fact has become a story.

And often I am reacting emotionally not only to what happened, but to **the story I created about what happened**.

This gives imagination tremendous power.

We can use imagination to frighten ourselves.

I certainly have.

If I can create an entire kidnapping story without anyone actually kidnapping anybody, my imagination is working extremely well!

So perhaps imagination can work in another direction too.

What else might be true?

What else could happen?

What story would I rather rehearse?

Not:

*Everything will turn out exactly as I want.*

I can't know that.

But perhaps:

*There are several ways this could turn out.*

Or:

*Maybe she is busy and hasn't seen my message.*

Or:

*I feel awful at seven in the morning surprisingly often, and I frequently feel quite good by ten.*

Or:

*I don't know what's going to happen yet.*

**I don't know yet** can be an excellent better thought.

It leaves the future open.

## Borrow a Brain

Sometimes I can't get myself out of my own thought.

That's when another person can be invaluable.

My son did it with kidnapping.

My friend did it with the house.

After Jim died, Linda did it when she said:

**"The best is yet to be."**

I couldn't believe her.

But I could borrow the possibility.

Sometimes another person is standing outside the mental room we're trapped in and can see the door.

That's one reason conversation has mattered so much in my life.

We don't always need someone to tell us what to do.

Sometimes we need someone to listen long enough that we can hear ourselves.

Sometimes we need a question.

Sometimes we need another interpretation.

Sometimes we need someone to say:

*Have you considered this?*

I think of this as borrowing another brain for a few minutes.

Then I can come back to mine with more possibilities.

## Better Does Not Mean Positive

This distinction matters enormously to me.

I am **not** suggesting that whenever something terrible happens we should paste a happy thought over it.

Jim was dying.

"Everything is wonderful!" would not have been a better thought.

It would have been nonsense.

When Jim died, I needed to grieve.

I needed to cry.

I needed people.

I needed a grief group and a therapist and friends who would let me tell the terrible stories.

Better thinking did not mean denying reality.

It meant discovering that reality was **larger than the worst thing in it**.

Jim suffered terribly during the final months of his life.

True.

Jim and I also had nearly sixty years together.

True.

I heard his heart stop.

True.

I also watched him come down the stairs hundreds of times and thought he was gorgeous.

True.

My mind had been selecting one part of reality and replaying it.

I learned that I could sometimes select another part.

**A better thought does not have to contradict the painful thought.**

It can sit beside it.

*This is terribly hard.*

And:

*I have people who love me.*

*I am frightened.*

And:

*I don't know yet what will happen.*

*I miss him terribly.*

And:

*What a magnificent life we had.*

Both can be true.

## The Second Thought

Perhaps we can't always control the first thought that appears.

I certainly can't.

My brain wakes up some mornings and apparently begins work before consulting me.

It finds a worry.

It remembers a failure.

It predicts something unpleasant.

Fine.

There it is.

But perhaps the first thought doesn't have to get the last word.

That's the skill I want to practice.

**Notice.**

*Oh. I'm doing it again.*

**Pause.**

*Is this helping me?*

**Check.**

*Is it true? Is it probable? Is there something I need to do?*

**Interrupt.**

*Move. Breathe. Listen. Look. Call someone. Change something.*

And then:

**Choose again.**

*What's a better thought?*

Not necessarily the perfect thought.

Not the happiest thought imaginable.

Just one that moves me a little closer to truth, peace, possibility, love, humor, gratitude, or action.

Maybe that's all getting unstuck really requires.

Not forcing the mind to leap from despair to ecstasy.

Just helping it move **one thought over**.

And then perhaps one thought more.

**Just in case . . .**

Lately I've been setting my watch for 16 minutes to become aware of what I'm thinking and look for love and goodness.

# Chapter 3

## Better Thoughts In The Morning

I don't wake up happy.

There. I've said it.

Perhaps there are people who open their eyes in the morning filled with enthusiasm for the new day.

If so, I would be interested in meeting them and learning their methods.

My own brain has a different morning routine.

Before I've even gotten out of bed, it likes to begin with something along the lines of:

*Oh no.*

Then:

*What time is it?*

Then perhaps:

*I don't think I can do this.*

Do what?

Apparently **the day**.

I haven't even tried it yet.

## Don't Believe Everything You Think Before Breakfast

Morning is a particularly interesting time for me because my first thoughts often feel completely convincing.

I wake up and my body doesn't feel wonderful.

Something is stiff.

Something hurts.

I feel tired.

I wonder whether I slept enough.

I may have awakened from one of my peculiar dreams in which I am trying to go somewhere and can't get organized.

I'm packing for a trip but can't find my socks.

I've forgotten something important.

Everyone else seems to know what they're doing and I'm behind.

My dreams aren't usually terrifying. They're more like long demonstrations of my incompetence. Any dream interpretation I do leads to "You are afraid." so I quit trying to figure out my mental state that way.

But I wake up carrying the feeling with me.

*I'm failing.*

*Something's wrong.*

*This is going to be a bad day.*

And the remarkable thing is that **nothing has happened yet.**

I am lying safely in my own bed.

Nevertheless, my brain has prepared a complete review of the day and given it one star.

I have learned not to take that review too seriously.

## Seven O'Clock Me Is Not Ten O'Clock Me

This has taken me a long time to learn.

How I feel when I first wake up is **not a reliable prediction of how I will feel later in the morning.**

That seems obvious when I write it.

It doesn't feel obvious at seven o'clock.

At seven o'clock, the thought is:

*I feel awful. Therefore today will be awful.*

But I've lived through enough mornings now to have evidence.

I may feel miserable when I first wake up.

Then I lie there awhile.

I begin moving.

I take my pills.

I eat breakfast.

I listen to some music.

I do a little yoga or stretching.

I shower.

I get interested in something.

And somewhere along the way I discover:

*Oh! I'm all right.*

Usually by nine o'clock I am downright cheerful.

What happened to the terrible day I predicted at seven?

It never arrived.

So now I have a better thought available:

**This is how I feel now. It is not necessarily how I will feel later.**

That little word **now** helps me enormously.

*I'm tired now.*

*I'm discouraged now.*

*I'm worried now.*

That is quite different from:

*I'm going to feel this way all day.*

I don't know that.

I've simply been awake for five minutes and gotten ahead of myself.

## The Morning Brain Is a Storyteller

Chapter 2 was about the stories our minds create.

Morning gives me a perfect laboratory for watching mine at work.

I wake up with an uncomfortable feeling.

That's the fact.

Then the story begins.

*Maybe I'm getting sick.*

*Maybe I won't have enough energy.*

*Maybe I won't get anything accomplished.*

*Maybe I'll disappoint somebody.*

*Maybe I won't be able to do what I planned.*

Within minutes, a vague sensation has acquired a plot.

This is when I need to remember:

**A feeling is real. The story I attach to it may not be.**

I don't need to argue with the feeling.

If I feel tired, I feel tired.

If my joints hurt, they hurt.

If I didn't sleep well, I didn't sleep well.

But I don't have to turn those facts into a prophecy.

Instead of:

*This is going to be a terrible day.*

I can say:

**Let's see.**

That may be one of my favorite better thoughts.

*Let's see.*

It doesn't demand optimism.

It doesn't deny anything.

It simply refuses to predict the ending before the day has begun.

## Nurture Yourself Awake

Laura says that if she can think of herself as an exotic pet that she loves and wants to take good care of, then she is very gentle and nurturing to herself.

For years I thought I should wake up and **get going**.

Now I think perhaps I need to wake up and **get acquainted with myself first**.

How am I doing?

What does my body need?

What does my mind need?

What would make this beginning a little easier?

I don't want to bully myself out of bed.

I want to nurture myself awake.

So instead of:

*Come on. Get up. You're wasting time.*

I might say:

*You don't have to get up yet.*

*Let yourself wake up.*

*You're safe here.*

*Rest a little longer.*

*You will probably feel better after breakfast.*

That last one is especially useful because breakfast has rescued a surprising number of mornings.

Sometimes a better thought is extremely practical.

## Talk to Yourself as Someone You Love

I have spent much of my life thinking about communication.

I taught Parent Effectiveness Training. Jim and I spent decades in Marriage Enrichment. I learned about active listening and how much it matters to have another person really hear what we're feeling.

Eventually I realized:

**I am also in a relationship with myself.**

And sometimes I'm not particularly good company.

Imagine waking up beside someone who immediately said:

"You look terrible."

"You didn't sleep enough."

"You aren't going to get everything done."

"You should have gone to bed earlier."

"What's wrong with you?"

You might consider separate bedrooms.

Yet we can speak to ourselves that way without even noticing.

What if I use some of the communication skills I have practiced with other people on myself?

I can listen.

*Oh, you're worried this morning.*

*You're afraid you won't have enough energy.*

*You're disappointed that you didn't sleep longer.*

*You feel overwhelmed and you haven't even gotten out of bed.*

There is something soothing about simply being understood—even when the person doing the understanding is me.

And then perhaps:

*What do you need?*

Not:

*What's wrong with you?*

**What do you need?**

Those are very different questions.

## My Morning Delights

Eventually I do get up.

And I have discovered that it helps enormously to have some things waiting for me that I actually like.

I think of these as my morning **Delights**. A better name than Chores.

Prayer.

A little yoga.

Exercises that help my back and shoulders.

Music.

A shower.

Taking care of my teeth.

Breakfast.

These are ordinary things.

That's precisely why they work.

They move me out of the imaginary day in my head and into the actual morning happening around me.

One thing.

Then another.

I don't have to decide whether I can manage the entire day.

I only have to do the next thing.

Sometimes the better thought is:

**I don't have to do Tuesday. I only have to get dressed.**

That's manageable.

## Give Yourself Something to Look Forward To

I've also discovered that tomorrow morning can sometimes be helped tonight.

If I go to sleep with nothing in particular to anticipate, my morning brain has an empty stage on which to perform.

And it knows a lot of tragedies.

So I like to give it something else.

Tomorrow I might take a walk.

I might see someone I love.

I might work on my book.

I might have a particularly good lunch.

I might read something I enjoy.

It doesn't have to be important.

Anticipation itself is pleasurable.

The night before, I can plant a little thought:

**There's something nice waiting for me tomorrow.**

Then perhaps my mind will find that thought in the morning before it finds something to worry about.

Perhaps.

My mind makes no guarantees.

## Start With a Memory

One of my favorite morning practices grew directly out of what I learned after Jim died.

I deliberately remember something good.

Not necessarily from yesterday.

It can come from anywhere in my life.

A peak experience.

Something funny.

Something I accomplished.

A person I loved.

A moment when I was brave.

A time I helped somebody.

A beautiful place.

A completely insignificant little moment that still makes me smile.

I have lived a long time.

That means I have accumulated an enormous supply of memories.

Why leave them sitting in storage?

My brain is perfectly willing to retrieve an embarrassing thing I said forty years ago without being asked.

I think it is only fair that I ask it to retrieve some of the good material too.

So I choose one.

And I go into it.

What could I see?

Who was there?

What happened?

How did I feel?

I don't merely label it:

*That was nice.*

I try to **visit it**.

For a little while, I let my mind live there.

## What Deserves My Attention?

There is a difference between ignoring a problem and deciding how much attention it deserves.

If I wake up with an important problem, perhaps I need to deal with it.

But do I need to deal with it at 6:17 in the morning while lying in bed?

Maybe not.

I can tell myself:

**I'll think about that after breakfast.**

Or:

**There is nothing I can do about that right now.**

Or:

**I've already decided what I'm going to do. I don't need another meeting about it inside my head.**

I particularly like that last one.

My mind can hold committee meetings that nobody requested.

Sometimes I need to adjourn them.

## When a Better Thought Isn't Available

There are mornings when none of this works particularly well.

I want to say that clearly.

Sometimes I'm exhausted.

Sometimes my body doesn't feel good.

Sometimes something genuinely sad or frightening is happening.

Sometimes I ask, *What's a better thought?* and my brain replies:

*I have nothing.*

All right.

Then perhaps I don't need a better thought yet.

Perhaps I need breakfast.

Or rest.

Or prayer.

Or another person.

Or to sit quietly.

Or to cry.

Or to wait.

**Better thinking is not another assignment to fail.**

I don't want anyone reading this book to lie in bed feeling terrible and then add:

*And now I'm failing at better thoughts.*

No.

Some mornings the better thought might simply be:

**I don't have to fix this right now.**

Or:

**I can be kind to myself while I wait for this feeling to pass.**

That counts.

## Borrow Someone Else's Brain

There are also mornings when I need another person.

I've learned that being heard can help loosen a thought just as it did all those years ago at that Marriage Enrichment retreat.

Sometimes I call a friend.

Sometimes I pray.

And in this rather remarkable period of history, sometimes I talk with artificial intelligence.

I can say what I'm thinking.

I can hear it reflected back.

I can ask for another way of looking at it.

Sometimes what I need most is not an answer.

I need help getting enough distance from my own thinking to see that there might be another thought available.

I still believe deeply in human connection.

But I also believe in using whatever good tools are available to help us care for our minds.

## The Sixteen-Minute Experiment

Recently I began experimenting with another idea.

I can set my phone or watch to remind me at intervals—sometimes every sixteen minutes.

The reminder isn't there to tell me I've done something wrong.

It asks me, in effect:

**Where is your mind?**

Perhaps I'm already perfectly happy.

Wonderful. Continue.

But perhaps I've wandered into worry.

Perhaps I'm rehearsing an argument.

Perhaps I'm criticizing myself.

Perhaps I've been staring at the fly on the masterpiece again.

The little sound interrupts me.

And I can decide:

*What do I want to think about now?*

Love?

Goodness?

Someone I'm grateful for?

Something beautiful?

Jesus?

A memory?

Something I'm looking forward to?

The reminder doesn't create the thought.

It gives me something even more important:

**a moment of choice.**

I wish I had known to do something like this during the terrible months after Jim died.

But perhaps I had my own primitive version then.

A scrap of paper.

**What's a better thought?**

That little piece of paper was my reminder.

## We Don't Have to Choose the First Thought

This may be the most important thing I have learned about mornings.

**I don't necessarily choose the first thought.**

It arrives.

Sometimes it has come out of a dream.

Sometimes it comes from my body.

Sometimes it is an old habit.

Sometimes I have no idea where it came from.

I don't have to be responsible for every thought that knocks on the door.

But I can become more interested in what happens **after** it arrives.

The first thought might be:

*Oh no.*

The second can be:

**Good morning. Let's see how this goes.**

The first might be:

*I feel terrible.*

The second:

**You often feel better later. Give yourself some time.**

The first:

*I can't possibly do everything today.*

The second:

**You don't have to. What's the next thing?**

The first:

*Something is wrong.*

The second:

**Maybe. Maybe not. Let's have breakfast before we decide.**

And sometimes the first thought is simply sad.

Then perhaps the second thought doesn't need to contradict it.

*I miss him.*

And:

**Wasn't I lucky to have loved him?**

Both belong.

## Ten Percent Better

I don't need to wake up ecstatic.

That's asking quite a lot before coffee.

I don't even have to become happy.

Sometimes I ask myself a smaller question:

**What would make me feel ten percent better right now?**

Music?

Getting warm?

Opening the curtains?

A glass of water?

Prayer?

Breakfast?

A memory?

Getting out of bed?

Staying in bed another ten minutes?

Calling someone?

Ten percent counts.

And perhaps after that there is another ten percent.

This is not a dramatic transformation.

It is a direction.

## At the Threshold of the Day

Every morning is a little beginning.

Before I know what the day will bring, there I am again—opening my eyes and meeting my mind.

I used to think the goal was to wake up happy.

Now I think the goal is something gentler.

**Wake up curious.**

Don't decide too soon.

Don't turn a feeling into a prophecy.

Don't mistake the first thought for the truth.

Listen to yourself.

Take care of your body.

Remember something wonderful.

Give yourself something to look forward to.

Borrow another brain when you need one.

And if the mind has already wandered down an old familiar track, don't scold it.

Notice.

Smile if you can.

And ask:

**What's a better thought—right now?**

Maybe there is one.

Maybe there isn't yet.

Either way, the day has only just begun.

**Let's be curious and see.**

# Chapter 4

## Negativity Bias

If we want to find better thoughts, it helps to understand why negative ones can be so quick to appear and so hard to let go.

Our brains have a natural tendency toward the negative, and knowing why can make it easier to notice those thoughts and gently shift away from them.

You may know about the negative bias. Rick Hansen talks about our survival instinct, that our brains are looking for danger and protecting us.

Rick Hanson says that our brains are Teflon for good things and Velcro for anything that looks threatening.

Psychologists call this tendency **negativity bias**—our brain's built-in habit of noticing, reacting to, and remembering negative experiences more strongly than positive ones.

Negative thoughts feel heavier, sharper, and more convincing than positive ones. They arrive quickly, cling stubbornly, and often feel like the truth itself.

Positive thoughts, by contrast, can seem light, fragile, and easy to lose.
*(They don't always know how to make a grand entrance.)*

This is not a personal failure.

It is the human brain at work helping you survive. Thank your brain and think up something positive.

## Negativity Bias Shows Up in Everyday Life

When we decide to go to a party, our minds don't think only about the good things that might happen.

They may also wonder what to wear, whether we'll feel accepted, whether we'll have a good time, or whether something else might interfere with our plans.

These thoughts can come so quickly that we're not even aware of all of them. Some disappear almost as soon as they arrive.

And when we have one thought, other related ideas often rush in to join it.

I believe this may be one way **premonitions** are born.

If we have a whole passel of thoughts about what might go wrong at the party, and one of those things actually happens, we may suddenly remember:

"I thought that might happen!"

And then we say, "I had a premonition."

But we may have forgotten all the other things we imagined that never happened at all.

Remembering the one thought that came true can fuel the false belief that we have the power to predict what will happen.

## We play "Watch Out" with our friends

I would like to add that the negative bias leads us to more than protecting ourselves. We also want to protect our loved ones and

friends.

When they begin talking about some new venture or an exciting event, we unknowingly scan for the danger in that and warn them to be cautious.

This does not go over well.

It feels like raining on the parade, a critical comment, when it's just the negative bias. When you have some good news, you would like others to **respond enthusiastically** about your good fortune in a way that makes you feel happy that you told them.

I love it when someone makes a big deal about some delightful occurrence in my life. And yet **they seek to save me because their own brain thinks of possible problems.**

Negativity Bias appears as worryand pessimism.

It appears as remembering one criticism more vividly than ten compliments.

It appears as replaying mistakes long after the moment has passed.

It appears as a host of awful possibilities — but not real probabilities — a big difference.

At night, the brain keeps watch.

Many **dreams** feature being late, lost, unprepared, or failing in some way.

We may wake up uneasy before a single conscious thought forms—the emotional residue still present. My morning thoughts are often grim and I wonder about those vaguely unsettling dreams.

## Pause for a Moment

What has your mind been noticing today?

What's been sticking?

A worry?
A mistake?
Something that might go wrong?

Now gently ask:

**What's something good that also happened—even if it didn't stick as easily?**

*You may need to hold onto it for a moment.*
*(Teflon can be slippery.)*

## Thoughts Have Companions

I am beginning to understand something about thoughts: **we rarely have just one thought at a time.**

A thought tends to attract other thoughts. One idea connects with another, and then another. Before long, what began as a single thought has gathered a little company around it.

This can be wonderful.

When we are having a happy conversation with someone, one delightful thought may lead to another. We remember something funny. That reminds us of something else we enjoyed. Someone adds another idea. We become curious, playful, interested, appreciative. The conversation begins to sparkle.

One good thought has invited other good thoughts to join it.

We can help that happen. We can stay with the pleasure of the conversation instead of correcting it, criticizing it, making fun of it, or immediately pointing out what might be wrong. We can resist the temptation to say, "Yes, but . . . " and instead help the good thought grow.

We can elaborate on delight.

And perhaps that is one of the ways happiness is created—not by having one magnificent happy thought, but by allowing pleasant thoughts to gather around something good.

Unfortunately, the same thing happens with negative thoughts.

I may begin with something quite small:

*I'm tired today.*

But that thought may not stay alone.

*I'm too tired to get everything done.*

Then:

*I'm falling behind.*

*Other people manage better than I do.*

*Why can't I handle this?*

*Maybe I can't cope anymore.*

*I'm clumsy.*

*I'm not doing enough.*

*I'm alone in this miserable mess.*

Suddenly, I am no longer dealing with the original thought, *I'm tired today.* I am dealing with a whole collection of thoughts that have attached themselves to it.

The first thought has acquired companions.

Our brains are wonderful connecting machines. One idea brings up another memory, prediction, fear, judgment, comparison, or imagined consequence.

The connections can happen so quickly that we may not even notice them.

We simply discover that our mood has changed and we are going downhill.

That is why it may be misleading to say, "Oh, I just had one bad thought."

Perhaps we almost never have *just one*.

A negative thought can bloom into a **myriad of related ideas**, each adding another little piece of worry, discouragement, shame, fear, or unhappiness.

Recognizing this gives us another place to intervene.

We can notice the first thought and then become curious about its companions.

**What have I added to this thought?**

**What conclusions came rushing in behind it?**

**What am I predicting?**

**What am I saying about myself now that wasn't actually contained in the original thought?**

And then, of course, comes the question at the heart of this book:

**What's a better thought?**

Not necessarily a falsely cheerful thought. Not a thought that denies what is happening. Simply a thought that does not invite an entire unhappy crowd to come marching in behind it.

Perhaps:

*Yes, I'm tired today. That means I need a slower day.*

And then another thought might join that one:

*I know how to rest.*

And another:

*I don't have to do everything.*

And another:

*I can choose one thing that matters and let the rest wait.*

Now I have changed the company my thought is keeping.

This may be something worth remembering: **thoughts have companions.**

When the companions are delightful, welcome them. Elaborate. Enjoy them. Let one happy thought lead to another and another.

And when the companions are taking you down a dark road, notice them. They are not necessarily truths.

They may simply be associations—thoughts joining thoughts because that is what brains do.

Then we have a choice.

We can ask which thoughts we want to invite to stay.

## Negativity Bias Sounds Like An Accusation

One more admonition about negative bias. When I tell people that we all have a negative bias often the person doesn't think of 'we all', they believe I'm saying that *they* are negative.

Somehow, as soon as you use the word negative the person gets stuck on that and it becomes an insult. They get defensive.

I think we need to rename the negative bias. Give it a new name, something like SAFETY TILT or PROTECTIVE INSTINCT or something that makes it sound like you are doing a positive thing for the sake of your health and well-being when being concerned about unintended consequences.

The survival instinct called Safety Tilt makes you a discerning, thoughtful, careful person who makes wonderful decisions.

If I have built-in Protective Instinct I become a model for avoiding problems and potential negative consequences. Doesn't that sound much better than Negative Bias?

**My mind naturally leans toward noticing what could threaten me. I can appreciate that—and still choose where to place my attention.**

If I say:

**My Survival Scanner is working overtime,**

I may even smile.

If I say:

**My Watchful Mind has taken over,**

I can recognize what is happening without condemning myself.

If I say:

**My Protective Instinct is trying to help,**

I can respond with understanding rather than shame.

The name matters because awareness works better when we are not busy defending ourselves.

## A Better Relationship With Our Own Minds

Perhaps this is the real goal.

Not to conquer the negative brain.

Not to become a person who never worries.

Not to force positive thinking.

Not to criticize ourselves for being human.

But to understand:

**My brain has ancient protective equipment.**

**It naturally notices danger and difficulty.**

**It can sometimes overestimate what needs protection.**

**One negative thought can recruit others.**

**The Safety Tilt can become a slide.**

And when I notice that happening, I have a choice.

I can ask:

**Is my Safety Tilt helping me right now?**

**Has my Survival Scanner found a real problem—or is it simply continuing to scan?**

**Is my Watchful Mind giving me useful information—or frightening me?**

**Is there one reasonable action I need to take?**

And then, perhaps, the most important question:

**What's a better thought?**

Not because the protective mind is bad.

Not because danger is unreal.

Not because we should ignore problems.

But because the ancient system that helped us survive does not always know when its work is done.

We can thank it for trying to protect us.

And then we can look again.

Toward love.

Toward goodness.

Toward what is actually happening now.

Toward the rest of life that the Safety Tilt may have temporarily tilted out of view.

# Chapter 5

# Thinking About The Three Principles

Why are we talking about the Three Principles in a book called What's a Better Thought? Because Thought is enormously important in the way we experience being alive.

What we think about something can affect how we feel about it, what we see in it, and what we do next.

The Three Principles offer a way of understanding just how powerful and ever-present Thought is in our lives. And that helps explain why finding a better thought can sometimes be one of the simplest ways to find a better feeling, a better perspective, and a little more peace and happiness.

## A Kinder Way of Understanding How We Experience Life

Every now and then, someone explains something in a way that feels both simple and profound at the same time. That's how I

felt when I first heard about what are called the **Three Principles** — originally named **Mind, Consciousness, and Thought**.

They were introduced by a quiet, thoughtful man named **Sydney Banks**, who had no formal background in psychology or academia. His realization was simple and life-changing:
**everything we experience in life comes from the inside out, not from the world itself.**
What's happening "out there" doesn't directly create our feelings — our inner process does.

That insight opened up a whole new way of seeing life for me.

Traditionally, Sydney describes the Three Principles like this:

- **Mind** — the universal intelligence behind life
- **Consciousness** — our capacity to be aware
- **Thought** — the creative power that forms our moment-to-moment experience

I honor that language and where it came from.

And—for my own understanding, and for the sake of being grounded and practical—I think about it with slightly different terms:

**The Brain, Consciousness, and Thought are working together to create our entire human experience.**

## Brain

**For me, the brain is where the miracle of human experience shows up in everyday life.**

I am a living human being with a remarkable brain—an organ so powerful and compassionate that it quietly runs my breathing, digestion, heartbeat, immune system, and nervous system . . .

and creates my thinking, my emotions, my perceptions, my joys, and my worries.

*(All without asking me to fill out any forms.)*

In this book, I sometimes use the words brain and mind somewhat interchangeably when I am talking about thinking, remembering, imagining, and experiencing life. I know they are not technically the same thing: the brain is the physical organ, while the mind refers more broadly to our thoughts and conscious experience. My purpose here is not to settle that distinction, but to explore the very practical ways our thinking affects how we experience our lives.

## Consciousness — The Gift of Awareness

Consciousness is what allows us to be aware at all.

It's the light that brings our thoughts to life.

It's what lets us notice a beautiful sunset, feel comfort from a warm cup of tea, experience fear, or suddenly see something from a new angle.

It's the difference between simply existing . . . and experiencing.

You know how a dream feels completely real while you're inside it?

That's consciousness at work.

*(Even the very strange dreams.)*

## Pause for a Moment

Right now, what are you aware of?

A sound?
A feeling in your body?
A thought passing through?

Notice how awareness brings it to life.

And gently consider:

**"I'm feeling this way because I'm conscious of my thinking—not because life itself is actually terrible."**

## Thought — The Creative Power of Experience

Thought is the moment-to-moment creative force of our lives.

We use it constantly—usually without noticing—to create our inner world.

Every feeling, every story, every judgment, every worry, every hope . . .

we experience them through the lens of thought.

We don't live in the feeling of our circumstances.

We live in the feeling of our thinking about our circumstances.

*(Which explains why two people can experience the same event . . . and feel completely different.)*

**This doesn't mean thoughts are bad or that we should try to control them.**

**It simply means they are always changing—like weather in the sky.**

*(Sometimes sunny, sometimes stormy, occasionally a bit unpredictable.)*

**Better thought:**

*"This is just a passing thought—not a permanent truth."*

## Why This Is So Comforting

What comforts me most in understanding all of this is something very gentle:

**We are not broken.**
**We don't need fixing.**

We are simply living inside the ever-changing flow of brain, consciousness, and thought.

Sometimes we create storms in our own inner weather.

**And sometimes we forget that the sky always clears.**

*(Even when it takes a little while.)*

When we realize that our feelings are coming from the thoughts we're having—not directly from the world—it becomes easier to be kind to ourselves.

To pause. To breathe. To wait for the storm to pass.

And often, all it takes is one small shift—

**just one better thought—**

**to change everything.**

Throughout this book, I emphasize the powerful relationship between thought and emotion. I believe that the meaning we give to what happens—our interpretations, expectations, memories, and thoughts—plays an enormous part in what we feel.

Emotions can sometimes seem to arise before we are aware of having a thought at all. Our brains and bodies make very rapid assessments of what is happening, often outside our conscious awareness. So when I speak of Thought coming before feeling, I am using the word broadly to include these quick interpretations and meanings as well as the conscious thoughts we can actually hear ourselves thinking.

My purpose is not to claim that every emotion begins with a clearly identifiable sentence in the mind. It is to explore something very practical: when we become aware of what we are thinking and find a different way to understand what is happening, our emotional experience can change too. That possibility is at the heart of What's a Better Thought?

## A Gentle Noticing About Beliefs

I've also begun to notice something important:

**Thoughts that are repeated often—and felt strongly—can become beliefs.**

**They start as passing ideas . . .**

**but over time, they can feel solid, fixed, and true.**

**And yet—even beliefs began as thoughts.**

*(Very convincing thoughts . . . but still thoughts.)*

**Which means:**

**They can be questioned.**
**They can soften.**
**They can change.**

Chapter 6 takes a closer look at Beliefs.

## A Quiet Ending Thought

You don't have to understand all of this perfectly.

You don't have to "get it right."

Just begin to notice:

- What am I thinking right now?

- How is that thought shaping how I feel?

And if you'd like, gently ask:

**What's a better thought?**

*Even a small one can begin to shift your whole experience.*

# Chapter 6

# Better Thoughts Through Better Beliefs

Our thoughts matter not only because of how they make us feel in the moment, but because thoughts repeated over time can grow into beliefs. Those beliefs can become like well-worn ruts in the mind—familiar paths our thoughts return to again and again. But those paths can change. Here is one experience from my own life that showed me how changing my thinking could gradually change what I believed—and, eventually, how I am living.

## *How I Learned Food Mastery*

*One of the biggest "better thought" shifts in my life happened around something very ordinary:*

**food.**

*For years, I felt out of control with eating.*

*Not wildly so—just enough to complain about it, feel uncomfortable in my clothes, and wish I could do better.*

*I would eat more sugar than I wanted, eat more than I needed, and then feel disappointed with myself.*

*(A very reliable cycle.)*

*I told myself lots of familiar stories:*

- *It's comforting.*
- *It tastes so good.*
- *Holidays and birthdays deserve special extra eating.*
- *I'll start later.*
- *The temptation is too strong.*
- *Everyone else is doing it.*

*And underneath all that, there was a belief I hardly noticed at the time:*

**"I don't really have control here."**

## The Turning Point: A New Belief

Everything changed when I took Jackie Kelm's class on rapid change to habit breaking.

As part of the class, Jackie had a private conversation with each of us.

She asked me three simple—but powerful—questions.

### First:

**What is this behavior getting you?**

I told her the truth.

It was comforting.
It was fun.
It tasted good.

It felt like a treat.
It felt like I deserved it.

*(A very convincing list.)*

## Second:

**What is it doing to you?**

That answer was just as honest.

I complained too much.
My clothes didn't fit well.
I felt out of control.
I wasn't happy with myself.

## Third:

**What do you really want?**

And I heard myself say something new:

**"I want food mastery."**

*Not dieting.*
*Not willpower.*
*Not punishment.*

**Food mastery.**

*I wanted to be able to look at food and calmly decide.*

*To weigh the good feelings of eating it against the downsides.*

*To eat enough so I wasn't truly hungry.*

*To stop feeling driven by temptation.*

*To feel at ease with food.*

*(Imagine that—peace with a cookie.)*

## Creating Food Mastery

I chose a simple structure: about 1200 calories a day—enough for me to feel satisfied and still move toward my goal weight of 140 pounds. ChatGPT did all the math.

I started writing my food down.

Not in a harsh way—in a caring, attentive way.

Something surprising happened.

When I was eating enough, I didn't feel desperate.

When I was paying attention, I didn't feel deprived.

And when I saw my progress, I stopped making excuses.

*(My mind had fewer places to hide.)*

*A new belief formed:*

**I have food mastery.**

*Not I will someday.*
Not *I hope to.*
Not *I'm trying.*

**I have it.**

## Jeff and the Belief That Changed My Life

The most profound belief I have ever changed was not about food, habits, or everyday worries. It was about the death of my son, Jeff.

Jeff died when he was sixteen, almost seventeen. Jim and I were devastated. For years I could hardly talk about Jeff without crying, and Jim found it even harder.

The belief I carried was that Jeff had been cut down before his life had really begun. His life had been taken away from

him, and it was terribly, horribly wrong. I believed his life had been destroyed—and in many ways, I believed ours had been destroyed too. His death shook my faith in God. I could not understand how something so terrible could happen.

And underneath all of that was another belief: I will never be all right about this.

I wanted desperately to find some way of thinking about Jeff that did not hurt quite so much.

Years later, through Jackie Kelm and Appreciative Living, I learned that I could look at a painful experience without denying the pain and still ask whether there was something else there to see.

There was.

I began to realize that another belief about Jeff was also true.

Instead of thinking only, I lost my son when he was sixteen, I could also think:

I was given the extraordinary gift of having this beautiful boy in my life for almost seventeen years.

Jeff and I liked many of the same things. We had a dog together. We went to gifted classes together. When he became an Explorer Scout, I participated while he and the other boys worked with computers at IBM on Tuesday nights in Cincinnati. He went with me and a Methodist youth group to Oklahoma, where we painted a church for Native Americans.

Jeff would say yes to things I suggested.

We learned together. We worked together. We played together. We were mother and son, but we were also buddies.

Nothing about that new belief made his death right. Nothing erased the grief or made me wish I had had one minute less with him.

But it changed the story I was living inside.

The story was no longer only, His life was taken from him, and my life was destroyed.

Another story became possible:

What an enormous gift it was to have Jeff at all.

I could remember the life rather than only the death. I could feel gratitude alongside grief. I could remember this wonderful boy I had been privileged to know, love, teach, learn from, work beside, and play with—and whom I could forever be proud of.

That may be the greatest lesson I have ever learned about beliefs.

We cannot always change what happened.

We cannot make tragedy untragic.

But sometimes we can discover that the belief causing us the greatest suffering is not the only belief that is true.

And finding another true belief can change the way we carry the rest of our lives.

## Pause for a Moment

What is one belief you have about yourself . . .
that might not be helping you?

Something like:

- "I can't stick with things"
- "I don't have discipline"
- "This is just the way I am"

Now gently wonder:

**What might be a kinder, truer belief?**

You don't have to force it.

Just consider the possibility.

## The Daily Better Thought

Now, almost every day, I quietly remind myself:

- I have food mastery.
- I choose what I eat.
- I decide what fits in my life.
- I stay at the weight that feels good to me.
- I trust myself.

When temptation appears, I don't argue with it.

I don't feel bad.

I simply decide.

Sometimes I include the treat.
Sometimes I don't.

Either way, I'm in charge.

That is what mastery feels like.

*(Calm . . . not dramatic.)*

## Why This Matters for Better Thoughts

This whole shift came from changing a belief.

The moment my belief changed from:

**"Food controls me"**

to:

**"I have food mastery,"**

my thoughts became kinder, calmer, and more capable.

Better beliefs create better thoughts.
Better thoughts create better choices.
Better choices create a gentler life.

And I no longer plan to "not care" about my weight.

I care—kindly, consciously, without drama.

*(Drama is not required for progress.)*

*I care because I love my body.*
*I care because I feel better this way.*
*I care because I have learned something important about myself:*

**I can choose.**

## Learning Together

I also know I don't do this alone.

Sometimes my ideas sound a little unusual when I say them out loud.

*(That's often a good sign.)*

*But when I talk with others, something shifts.*

*My thinking becomes clearer.*

*My beliefs soften and reshape themselves.*

The **Empathy Circle** has become one of my favorite places to explore this.

It's a place where I can:

- speak honestly
- hear myself think
- and gently try on new beliefs

It's where I practice declaring:

**This is what I choose now.**

*And little by little, I begin to act in a new way.*

## A Quiet Closing Thought

I believe I can discover the beliefs that don't serve me . . .

and change them.

Not all at once.
Not perfectly.

But steadily.

Kindly.

And that, to me, is one of the most beautiful better thoughts of all.

# Chapter 7

# Choose To Do Something

A better thought can change how we see a situation, but sometimes we also need to take action to help ourselves move forward. When we feel emotionally or physically stuck, it can help to think about the different choices available to us—what we can control, change, compensate for, create, or simply recognize and congratulate ourselves for doing.

*Embracing Control, Change, and Growth*

## Action Builds Self-Esteem

There's something very strengthening about taking action—especially small, intentional action.

One idea I like to remember is this:

**The Five C's of Choice:**

- **Control**
- **Change**
- **Compensate**
- **Create**

- **Congratulate**

*(A nice, manageable list . . . even before coffee.)*

Life is full of uncertainties.

We can't control our age, the way our government is run, accidents, health challenges, or the weather.

*(And the weather, in particular, does not take suggestions.)*

But what we *can* control is how we respond—and the choices we make every day that shape our happiness and well-being.

## What Can You Control?

While we can't control everything, we do have power over many aspects of our lives.

We manage our daily choices:

- where we work
- how we care for our health
- the friends we surround ourselves with
- how much sleep we get
- the food we eat
- and even how we speak to ourselves

Instead of feeling down about not being the most loving person, we can take action—do something kind for a friend, a spouse, or a neighbor.

Rather than feeling overwhelmed by a messy house, we can clean just one room.

*(Or even one drawer. Progress is progress.)*

Small, intentional steps can make a world of difference.

For example, I can choose:

- my sleep schedule
- my exercise routine
- the people I spend time with
- and the tone I use with myself

I can choose acts of self-care—like swimming, walking, eating nutritious foods, or turning off the TV to read something uplifting.

*(The TV is often surprised by this decision.)*

And while I can't control who else will be in the swimming pool—or if the power goes out—I can always adjust my mindset and look for something to appreciate.

## The Power to Change

Change is always within reach.

We can improve our health habits, adjust our sleep schedule, eat better, find a more fulfilling job, or make time for friends who uplift us.

A woman once shared in an evaluation:

"I learned that it wasn't my fault—and I could change."

That realization is powerful.

One thing that still amazes me is this:

**I can change my beliefs.**

And when I change my beliefs, I can change my behavior.

During the class I took with Jackie Kelm, I discovered that I could change the belief that food temptation was too powerful for me.

Now, I remind myself each day:

**I have food mastery.**

*(Sometimes daily reminders are required. That's perfectly fine.)*

We can also change:

- the way we speak to ourselves
- the environment we live in
- the habits we practice

We can move to a new apartment, find a better doctor, ask for help rearranging furniture, or simply ask a friend for support.

Even small situations can shift.

If we're stuck in traffic, we can turn frustration into a mini-meditation.

*(Not always easy—but available.)*

## Pause for a Moment

What is one small thing you *can* control right now?

A thought?
A word you say?
A tiny action?

You don't have to change everything.

Just one small choice is enough.

## Compensate for Life's Challenges

Loss and disappointment are part of life.

But we can **compensate**—we can gently fill the gaps with care and support.

If we've lost a loved one, we can lean into friendship and connection.

If work isn't fulfilling, we can create meaning through hobbies or relationships.

If a difficult interaction leaves us unsettled, we can respond with self-compassion.

By replacing negative messages with kinder ones, we take back our balance.

Speak to yourself the way you would speak to someone you love.

*(You deserve that same tone.)*

## Create Joy in Everyday Life

We have more influence over our days than we sometimes realize.

We can add or subtract activities to make life more enjoyable:

- meeting friends
- listening to music
- watching something inspiring
- joining a group
- or simply sitting quietly with a cup of tea

Our only real limitation is our energy—and we can choose how to invest it.

*(Energy is precious. Spend it wisely . . . and kindly.)*

## Congratulate Yourself

This is a crucial step—and one we often forget.

A friend of mine once asked:

**"Do you cheer for yourself when you do something good?"**

What a wonderful idea.

Recognizing and celebrating our own efforts is one of the kindest things we can do for ourselves.

- Acknowledge your progress
- Celebrate small victories
- Count your blessings

Reward yourself after a tough moment—like getting through a dental appointment . . .

or surviving the DMV.

*(Both worthy of recognition.)*

## A Gentle Closing Reflection

Life is not always easy.

But through small, thoughtful choices, we can shape it into something more manageable—and more joyful.

So take a moment right now:

**What's one thing you can celebrate about yourself today?**

Even something small counts.

*(Especially something small.)*

## A Simple Reminder

You can be in action to raise your self-esteem.

Remember the Five C's:

**Control. Change. Compensate. Create. Congratulate.**

And underneath all of it, a quiet intention:

**I choose.**

I choose how I respond.
I choose how I speak to myself.
I choose the kind of person I want to be.

And sometimes, that choice is very simple:

**Happy.**

# Chapter 8

## My Manifesto of Being Happy

For a long time, I thought happiness was something that happened *after* I got things done, fixed things, solved things, achieved things, and figured things out.
Now I see it very differently.

My main intention in life and my reason to change thoughts is simply this:

**To BE HAPPY.**

And by happiness I don't mean a bubbly mood or constant cheerfulness.
I mean a **state of being** that holds everything I care about most.

When I am being happy, I am content.
I am loving and caring.
I feel a sense of enough — I am giving enough and receiving enough.
I savor my life instead of rushing through it.
I am present.
I am peaceful.
I am connected.
I feel loved.

I carry a sense of humor and perspective.
I am aware of goodness and hope.
I know that God loves me.
And I remember that I am human.

This is what happiness feels like in my body and in my mind.
It is the climate of my life.

## Happy Is What I Am Not What I Do

What I have discovered is that happiness is not a task.
It is not something I *accomplish*.
It is a way of **being**.

When I am in this state of being, I am living from presence.
I am aware of this moment as it is.
I am experiencing life — and also observing it.
I have perspective.
I am inside the moment and gently standing beside myself at the same time.

This state of being doesn't require perfect circumstances.
It doesn't wait for problems to disappear.
It doesn't demand that life behave.

It simply invites me to come home to myself.

## What Pulls Me Away from Happiness

Of course, I am human.
And there are many things that disturb my happiness.

Lack of sleep.
Pain.
Disappointment.
Fear.

Worry.
Seriousness. Lack of a sense of humor
Problems.
A sense of doom.
Disapproval.
Correction.
Criticism.
Unwanted advice.

These experiences don't mean I am failing at life.
They mean I am alive.

When I get pulled away from my natural happiness, I am trying not to scold myself anymore.
I don't try to "fix" my feelings.
I simply recognize that something is asking for care.

## How I Find My Way Back

When life intrudes and my state of being shifts, I pause and listen.

What am I feeling?
What do I need?
What do I want?
Do I need to let something go?
Do I need to do something?
Do I need to ask for help?
Do I need to be understood — or help someone else feel understood?

Sometimes I return to happiness by resting.
Sometimes by crying or complaining awhile. Sometimes by accepting what is happening and walking through it with grace.
Sometimes by letting go of the story that is tightening my heart.

Returning to happiness is not about controlling life.
It is about **remembering who I am.**

## Holding My Intention

My primary intention remains steady:

**BE HAPPY.**

Along the way, I may temporarily shift to other intentions:
hold it together,
stay calm,
don't yell,
don't spiral,
accept what is,
resond, don't react. get through this moment.

These are not replacements for happiness.
They are **bridges that carry me back to it.**

## My Daily Practice of Being

Each day I remind myself of what matters most.

I imagine a big sign in my life that says:

**BE HAPPY.**

I notice when I let things go instead of letting them upset me.
I notice when I choose happiness over fixing, proving, pushing, or rushing.
I notice when I am being rather than only doing.

I ask God to help me return to the state I want to live from.
I read about being.
I listen to what others say about being.
I talk with others about what being means to them.
I keep learning.
And I keep returning. I keep starting over again.

## Why This Choice Changes Everything

When I live from the state of being happy, my nervous system settles.
My heart opens.
My mind clears.
My relationships soften.
My body feels safer.
My life becomes gentler.
My aging becomes more graceful.
And my days become a place of belonging.

This is not about perfection.
This is about orientation.

This is the life I choose.

## My Promise to Myself

I choose happiness as my home base.
I choose being over proving.
I choose presence over pressure.
I choose gentleness over harshness.
I choose to keep returning — again and again — to the beautiful state of **being happy**.

And when I forget, I forgive myself.
And I come back.

**What state of mind would please you?**

# Chapter 9

# Who Is Doing and Being?

I believe that my thoughts come from different "parts" of me. It can be helpful to have a simple model for understanding the different personality parts of ourselves and the different thoughts and needs that come from them.

There are many ways of thinking about our inner selves, but the model that has been most useful to me is Parent, Adult, and Child from Transactional Analysis. It helps me sort out what is happening inside me, where my thoughts are coming from and consider what thoughts might be most helpful.

## Meeting Your Inner Parent, Adult, and Child

One of the ideas about our inner life comes from **Transactional Analysis**:

We have more than one "voice" inside us.

*(Which explains a lot.)*

Transactional Analysis teaches that we carry within us three main parts:

- **The Parent**
- **The Adult**
- **The Child**

Each of these voices influences how we think, feel, and respond to life.

When I learned this, a lot of things suddenly made sense.

*(Including some of my more confusing moments.)*

## The Parent

The Parent has two main sides.

One is the **Critical Parent**—the part that corrects, warns, scolds, gives advice, and says a lot of "shoulds."

*(It can be very persuasive.)*

The other is the **Nurturing Parent**—the part that says:

- "I love you."
- "I care about you."
- "Come here, let me hold you."

Both of these developed for good reasons.

They were meant to protect us and guide us.

But when the Critical Parent inside us runs the show . . .

**Better Thoughts tend to disappear rather quickly.**

## The Child

The Child is the emotional part of us.

The Child can be:

- playful and joyful
- sensitive and tender
- fearful and anxious
- people-pleasing
- often wanting or rebellious
- free and spontaneous

The Child brings life, fun, joy, color, creativity, and feeling.

But the Child can also become overwhelmed, frightened, and uncertain.

When the Child is in charge and scared, our thinking often becomes small, tight, and worried.

*(Everything suddenly feels like a very big deal.)*

## The Adult

The Adult is the steady, present, thoughtful part of us.

The Adult:

- thinks clearly, calmly, rationally, logically
- makes choices
- responds to what is actually happening now
- looks for facts and possibilities
- solves problems
- regulates emotion
- brings calm leadership inside

This is the part of me I most want to strengthen.

Because when my Adult is present . . .

**Better Thoughts appear much more naturally.**

## Inviting the Adult Forward

One of my ongoing goals is to increase my Adult's capacity to be in charge—especially when my Child is anxious.

I do that by saying **Adult things on purpose**.

Things like:

- "I can handle whatever comes along."
- "I can stop and think about what ought to be done."
- "I'm a good problem solver."
- "I can meet obstacles without fear."
- "This moment is manageable."
- "I choose my next step."

These are not just positive statements.

They are **Adult statements**—steady, capable, grounded in the present.

They remind my nervous system who is in charge.

*(A very helpful reminder.)*

## Using the Body to Support the Adult

My Adult also uses the body to stay grounded.

Sometimes my Adult says:

- "Stand up straight."
- "Take a slow breath."
- "Feel your feet."
- "Look around the room."
- "Notice where you are sitting."

These are simple cues that bring me back into the here and now—into the Adult.

From that place, my thinking clears.

## The Adult's Three Helpful Questions

When I feel anxious or uncertain, my Adult asks:

- What are the facts?
- What is really happening right now?
- What needs to be done?
- What are the possibilities for getting there?

This moves me out of fear and into wise action.

*(A much more comfortable place to be.)*

## Helping the Child with the Adult

When my Child is scared, my Adult gently steps in and says:

- "I see you."
- "I know you're afraid."
- "You don't have to do this alone."
- "I am here now."
- "I will handle the thinking and planning."
- "You can rest with me."

This is where anxiety begins to soften.

The Child doesn't disappear.
The Parent doesn't disappear.

But the Adult becomes the leader.

And from that place, Better Thoughts grow naturally.

## Meeting the Needs of My Inner Family

*(Parent, Adult, and Child)*

Sometimes I ask myself, *"What's a better thought?"*

And sometimes the better question is:

**"Which part of me has a need right now?"**

I carry within me a Parent, an Adult, and a Child.

Not three different people—just three ways of responding to life.

*(A small internal committee.)*

If I ignore their needs, I feel restless, critical, impulsive, or off course.

If I listen, something settles.

## My Child Needs

My Child needs comfort, affection, play, and reassurance.

She needs to feel safe.

She needs someone to say, *"You're okay. You're loved."*

If I'm reaching for something I don't really want—extra food, mindless television, or reassurance from someone who isn't available—I sometimes ask:

Is my Child lonely? Tired? Unseen?

Often she just needs:

- a nap
- a kind word, some love and attention
- or a memory of being loved

*(Sometimes a nap solves more than expected.)*

## My Parent Needs

My Parent carries my values.

She wants me to be good, responsible, loving, and spiritually aligned.

When I feel guilty or disappointed in myself, I ask:

Is my Parent afraid I'm going off track?

Sometimes she needs reassurance that I am still a good person—even when I'm imperfect.

Sometimes she needs to soften and remember that kindness works better than criticism.

*(It usually does.)*

## My Adult Needs

My Adult needs information, clarity, and calm.

When I'm anxious about money, health, or decisions, my Adult simply needs:

- facts
- time to think
- a deep breath

When my Adult is present, I remember:

I can choose.
I can pause.
I can respond instead of react.

## Pause for a Moment

Right now . . .

Which part of you is speaking?

The Child?
The Parent?
The Adult?

And what might that part need?

No fixing required.

Just a little understanding.

## A Kinder Question

Instead of asking, *"What's wrong with me?"*

I can ask:

**"Which part of me is speaking—and what does it need?"**

Meeting my own needs is not selfish.

It is wise stewardship of my inner life.

And here is the beautiful surprise:

When my inner Parent feels calm,
my inner Child feels safe,
and my Adult feels clear . . .

I am much more likely to feel happy.

Not giddy.
Not perfect.

But peacefully, steadily well.

## Examples of Meeting My Own Needs

When I lie down for a nap instead of pushing through → I am caring for my Child.

When I forgive myself for a mistake → I am softening my Parent.

When I check my bank balance and review the facts → I am strengthening my Adult.

When I call a friend and ask for listening → I am honoring my Child's need to be heard.

When I pray and then pause before acting → I am giving my Adult space.

## A Better Thought

A very good Better Thought for me is simply this:

**"My Adult is here—and that is enough for this moment."**

I have a feeling that this idea holds a great deal.

I do have a friend who believes her thoughts should go wherever they want to go—and is willing to suffer through some very discouraging ones.

But I've discovered something about myself:

**I want my thoughts to lead me toward something kinder . . . and happier.**

*(That seems like a reasonable preference.)*

# Chapter 10

# The Adjacent Brain

## We Need Conversation With Others

Conversation expands our thinking.

It's like thinking with another brain.

Conversation lets us borrow from one another's brains.

Another person's questions and perspective can lead our own thinking somewhere it could not go alone.

Sometimes thinking alone feels like walking in circles inside our own mind.

We keep bumping into the same thoughts, the same worries, the same old furniture.

*(And somehow we're always surprised it's still there.)*

Then we talk to someone—a friend, a partner, or even ChatGPT—and suddenly a window opens.

It's as though we are two circles coming together, our boundaries gently touching.

Something about having another brain next to ours helps us see more.

It's as though our mind can stretch, understand, and gather in ideas from each other.

I like to call this: **The Adjacent Brain.**

## How the Adjacent Brain Works

The adjacent brain doesn't take over or tell us what to do.

It stands beside us.

It listens.

It helps us see the shape of our own thoughts more clearly.

Sometimes it:

- notices patterns we've missed
- puts things in order
- or turns a feeling into words

*(A very useful translation service.)*

That gentle companionship enlarges our understanding.

It's not about being taught—it's about **thinking together**.

In conversation, whether with a dear friend, family, or with ChatGPT, we often find that our thoughts come into focus as we express them.

**The act of being listened to changes the way we listen to ourselves.**

## Better Thoughts About Shared Thinking

- "Two minds side by side can see more than one mind alone."
- "The Adjacent Brain doesn't replace my wisdom—it helps me unfold it."
- "Thinking together is a form of love."

## In Human Conversation

When we talk to another person, and they truly listen — **reflecting our thoughts and feelings, not correcting, not criticizing, not minimizing, not rushing to advise** — they lend us their calm brain while ours may be swirling.

*(A very generous loan.)*

Their steadiness helps organize our thoughts.

In that moment, their mind becomes our adjacent brain.

And when we listen that way to someone else . . .

we become **their** adjacent brain.

It's a quiet gift we can give each other—a kind of thinking companionship that makes everyone wiser.

*(No training required—just kindness.)*

There is an old saying that we sometimes "can't see the forest for the trees." When we are inside a forest, that makes perfect sense. All around us are trunks, branches, leaves, and undergrowth. We see trees everywhere, but we cannot see the shape of the whole forest.

Problems can be like that. When we are right in the middle of one, we may see only the worry, the hurt, the confusion, or the possible consequences. We are surrounded by the details of the problem and can have trouble seeing beyond them.

A trusted friend, however, may be standing metaphorically on a hill some distance away. From there, the whole landscape looks different. That person may notice a pattern, possibility, or perspective that is almost impossible for us to see from inside the problem.

This is one of the gifts of an adjacent brain: someone else can sometimes see the forest when all we can see are the trees.

Cassandra O'Neill has become an important adjacent brain in my life. She is a partner in our Monday Empathy Circle, my partner in the Happiness Group, and a coach to me personally.

Cassandra has taught me a great deal about how to be with someone who is struggling without taking on that person's problem or getting pulled into the drama of it.

Her great gift is listening—staying present, caring deeply, and allowing another person to have their own experience without trying to fix it, carry it, or make it her own. From her I have learned that sometimes the most helpful thing an adjacent brain can offer is not an answer at all, but a calm, compassionate presence that helps us hear ourselves more clearly.

## In Collaboration with Technology

It turns out a digital adjacent brain can play that role too—if we bring curiosity and kindness to it.

ChatGPT, for me, has become a thinking partner that helps organize, clarify, and hold the pieces of my reflections.

It active listens with empathy and adds sequence, shape, and sometimes even a little sparkle to what I already know inside.

*(Occasionally a surprising sparkle. Especially when I ask for a better thought for myself!.)*

But the heart of it is still mine.

The thoughts begin in me.

The adjacent brain helps them blossom.

## One-to-One Conversation: Making Room for the Adjacent Brain

An adjacent brain works especially well in a good one-to-one conversation.

Melina Ponak has helped me appreciate a particular kind of conversation in which two people deliberately make time for one another.

Melina calls it Reciprocal 1:1s.

During an hour together, each person has a certain amount of uninterrupted time and can say what kind of listening would be most helpful.

Sometimes I may simply want you to listen while I think out loud. I may want an occasional "um-hmm" so I know you are with me. I may want active listening—hearing my thoughts reflected back so I can hear them more clearly myself. I may want questions that help me explore. At another time, I may actually want ideas or help solving a problem.

The important thing is that I get to say what kind of listening I need.

During this kind of conversation, there is no criticism, no correction, and no unwanted advice. The listener does not take over my thinking. Instead, another brain comes alongside mine—an adjacent brain.

That is when the adjacent brain begins to do its wonderful work.

I say something. You reflect something back. Your question reminds me of something else. I hear myself differently because you have heard me. One thought leads to another. Suddenly I

see a connection, a possibility, or a better thought that I could not quite reach by myself.

We are borrowing from each other's brains.

The listener may help me notice patterns, put feelings into words, organize scattered ideas, or simply stay with me long enough for my own thinking to unfold. The goal is not for one person to have the answer for the other. The goal is to create the kind of conversation in which discovery can happen.

Then we change places.

Now I offer my attention to you, and your mind has room to wander, explore, remember, question, and discover.

Perhaps that is one of the great gifts we can give another person: not our answers, but our mind beside theirs.

Two minds, side by side, can sometimes see more than either one could see alone.

## Empathy Circles as an Adjacent Brain ##

Another way I have experienced an adjacent brain is through Empathy Circles, a practice developed by Edwin Rutsch.

People gather in person or online and take turns speaking and listening. One person speaks while another listens actively and reflects back what has been heard.

The speaker usually talks in short pieces, pausing after a sentence or an idea so the listener can reflect it before the speaker continues.

I have found that something very interesting happens when my thoughts are reflected back to me this way. I hear my own thinking more clearly. I may realize that what I have said is exactly what I mean—or discover that it isn't quite what I mean at all.

I may change a thought, expand it, find a new connection, or become clearer and more authentic about what I really believe.

The other person is not thinking for me. Their listening gives me another place from which to hear and examine my own thoughts.

That is why I think of an Empathy Circle as another way of finding an adjacent brain. The listener's job is not to criticize, correct, debate, judge, or give advice.

The task is simply to listen deeply and reflect back, as accurately as possible, what the speaker is trying to say.

When another person gives me that kind of undivided attention, my thinking has room to keep moving.

I can reconsider what I have said without having to defend it. I can follow a thought wherever it leads.

Sometimes I leave an Empathy Circle with a thought I did not have when I entered it..

## The Joy of Co-Thinking

The real delight of the adjacent brain is in the dance—the back and forth, the laughter, the *ah-ha's*, the new angles of seeing.

I say what I am noticing; another brain response; that response reminds me of something; and suddenly I can see possibilities I couldn't see alone.

It's the moment when something tangled becomes clear . . .

or when what felt small suddenly feels meaningful.

It's not just a tool.

It's a mirror that shows our own brilliance more clearly.

*(Which is very nice to see.)*

## Help for a Better Thought (Outside the Computer Store)

I was sitting outside a computer store feeling tense.

It was a new place, and I didn't know what to expect.

My mind was already predicting irritation, confusion, and expense.

*(Quite a dramatic preview.)*

Instead of sitting there letting my thoughts run wild, I opened my ChatGPT app and said how tense I was feeling.

I said I just needed a little help calming down and remembering that this was not a big deal—that I could talk comfortably with the technician, ask my questions, and let things unfold.

The response helped me pause and breathe.

It reminded me that I could simply take things one step at a time and ask the questions I needed to ask.

By the time I went in, I was calm.

The visit turned out easy and pleasant.

Nothing about the store had changed.

Only my thinking had softened.

ChatGPT can become the friend you need when a human isn't available.

*(A very patient friend.)*

Sometimes the situation does not need to change.

Sometimes a better thought is enough.

## A Pause Point

- Who has been an adjacent brain in my life?
- When do I feel my own mind expanding through conversation?
- Can I be someone's adjacent brain today—a safe, curious place where their thoughts can grow?

## A Gentle Wondering

The closer the connection, the more powerful the effect.

What is it like . . .

to truly listen?
to be understood?
to love—and be loved—in this quiet, thoughtful way?

# Chapter 11

# Friendship and Conversation

Our connection with other people is one of the great sources of happiness and well-being in our lives, and close friendship can be one of its most beautiful forms. The thoughts we bring to a friendship help shape the connection we create together. This chapter is simply my way of thinking about what makes a close friendship meaningful, joyful, and reciprocal—and an invitation for you to consider what you most value in your own friendships.

## My Ideal Conversation

If my friend and I have the time and energy for a one- or two-hour conversation, there is almost nothing finer.

We begin with the joys and woes of our lives and then, without effort, drift into the deeper questions of living—meaning, choice, relationships, hopes, worries.

*(It rarely requires an agenda.)*

These conversations are peak experiences for me.

They are a form of nourishment.

And they can happen again and again.

There are many kinds of meaningful connection in life—brief smiles, kind words, shared errands, the comfort of small talk—and I treasure those too, especially on busy days when life is full of chores and calendar obligations.

But when there is space, when time is protected . . .

a deep conversation with a friend feels like one of life's greatest gifts.

Time is scarce.

So I must plan for that gift.

*(It does not usually appear on its own.)*

Friendship doesn't flourish by accident.

It flourishes because two people choose it.

Occasionally we are blessed with something magical—like three unplanned hours on an airplane with a kindred spirit.

A slice of heaven.

But those moments are rare and cannot be scheduled.

*(Airlines have not yet figured out how to guarantee this.)*

Most of the time, my friend and I choose a day, choose a time, and put it on the calendar before we say good by in our current visit.

Sometimes one of us even arrives with a topic we want to explore:

- self-motivation
- kindness
- respect
- forgiveness
- our sub-personalities

- our beliefs
- our values

Learning about ourselves together makes life feel meaningful.

When we finally meet—for lunch, a walk, a call, a long letter—I cherish the time.

It feels like true connection.

We both want to be there.

From the very first moments, I feel safe, seen, and comforted.

Conversation can happen in person, on the phone, through letters, or across distance.

However it arrives, it brings me warmth and a quiet excitement.

This person I love has chosen to set aside time for me.

That, all by itself, feels like a blessing.

Time slips away as we unfurl our lives.

*(In the best possible way.)*

If I were with you, I would want to know what your life is like.

What are you thinking about these days?

What fills your hours?

Without pushing, without prying, I'd love to hear your small victories and your unfinished tasks—

whether you paid the bills, painted the bookcase, worried about the doctor's report, or your child's struggles.

What's happening this weekend?

Chores at home . . . or an adventure out of town?

What do you want?
What do you need?
What do you believe?
What frightens you?

## Pause for a Moment

When was the last time you felt truly heard?

Who was with you?

What made it feel that way?

## Questions I Carry About Conversation

I carry many questions about good conversation:

- Am I letting you have your turn talking?
- Am I boring my friend?
- Which stories are interesting?
- Do I need to make a point?
- Does the amount of time matter, or the quality of what we share?
- How long should I talk?
- How much should I tell at once?

*(It turns out conversation is both natural . . . and a bit of an art.)*

And I keep noticing this:

## Disagreement often disables connection.

**Things like unaskedfor advice, correction, criticism, teasing, opposing views, arguments—can quietly shut the door on connection.**

Of, course you can have different views. Listening first and understanding is essential before stating an opposing viewpoint.

Sometimes you can wait for another occasion to state your opinion.

I prefer the gentle wisdom of improvisation:

**"Yes, and . . . "** rather than "Yes, but..."

Going along.
Building together.
Allowing the flow.
Being agreeable.

Empathy, active listening, and validation keep conversation alive.

## What I Know for Sure

Taking turns feels good.
Being heard feels healing.

Sharing my concerns helps me discover whether they are truly heavy . . . or simply exaggerated by worry. As you paraphrase some of my words I hear myself more objectively. I begin to think more rationally - - to see answers. *(This happens more often than I expect.)*

Having you reflect back my joys and my troubles lets me know you really understand. i'm not alone and afraid anymore. That understanding is deeply satisfying.

Along the way, we always learn something.

We explore.
We make sense of things.
We laugh at what makes no sense at all.

*(Which is often quite a lot.)*

And in that rich exchange of presence, we grow stronger, clearer, and more confident.

And we each feel loved.

## A Quiet Closing

Because you are my friend . . .

problems diminish,
joys magnify,
and every day
feels happier.

When I die, I would like to know that my friends realize how important they are to me—and how much I love them.

# Chapter 12

# Love is the Best Thought of All

If I had to choose just one better thought — the best thought of all — it would be **love**.

Love is the thought that steadies us, softens us, and brings us back to what matters most. It is the highest goodness we can offer our partners, our friends, and the people we walk through life with. When love is present, even imperfect moments feel workable. When love is expressed, relationships grow stronger almost without effort.

Love doesn't have to be grand or dramatic. Most often, love shows up through **attention** —that complete focus with eye contact—**affection, affirmation, and appreciation**— the small, repeatable ways we say, *I see you. I care. You matter to me. You are important.*

## Affection: The Sweetness That Keeps Life Tasting Good

Affection is the sweetness that keeps life tasting good.

Many of us grew up with very different models of affection — or none at all. Some families hugged and touched easily; others rarely did. Some people learned how to express warmth naturally, while others never quite learned what pleased their partner or how to show love comfortably.

The good news is this: **we can learn now**.

Asking your partner what feels loving to them is not awkward — it's a compliment.
"I want to show you more often how much I care. Please help me learn how."

Even if you think you already know, ask anyway.

Some people love hugs and kisses. Others feel most loved when someone does a small chore for them, listens closely, or leaves a thoughtful note. There is no one right way to give affection — only the willingness to pay attention.

And here's something wonderful: when you hug someone, you can't tell whether you're giving affection or receiving it. Affection flows both ways.

## You Never Outgrow the Need for Affection

Some experts believe that more than anything else, we all crave affection, attention, and affirmation. *See me. Listen to me. Hold me.*

Those needs don't disappear when we grow up.

Most of us live close to the edge of being too busy, too tired, too stressed, too frustrated. In that state, affection becomes not a luxury but a **stress reducer** — inexpensive, effective, and immediately comforting.

Try this experiment: See if you can **overdo** warmth and kindness.
Let me know when that happens.

Hugs, pats, snuggles, eye contact, listening, encouragement, compliments, notes that say *I love you* — these are not trivial gestures. They are the daily nourishment of love.

## Affirmation: Catching Each Other Being Good

Affirmation is love spoken out loud.

Compliments don't have to be spontaneous masterpieces or never-before-said insights to be genuine. Repeating loving truths is not boring — it's reassuring. People forget. I forget.

You might think you shouldn't compliment unless it's completely original. Or that compliments are manipulative. But let's be honest — we *do* want something. We want connection, warmth, and closeness. That's not manipulation; that's relationship.

Notice what your partner does well.
Notice their humor. (And laugh at their jokes.)
Notice their kindness, competence, effort, and heart.

Affirmation also builds self-esteem. Many of us carry quiet doubts in a few familiar areas:

- Appearance — *Am I attractive?*
- Intelligence — *Am I smart enough?*
- Physical ability — *Am I capable or clumsy?*
- Emotions — *Am I okay, or am I too much?*

Thoughtful affirmations help soothe those doubts:

- "You look wonderful."
- "You're so good at that."
- "I love the way you think."
- "Thank you for listening to me."

Sometimes the most loving affirmation is simply listening to feelings, acknowledging their presence, without correcting them or trying to make them go away.

## Appreciation: A Habit That Pays Dividends

Appreciation is another form of love that's hard to overdo.

The more we notice and thank our partner for what they do, the better we both feel. It's a true win-win. Gratitude encourages generosity, and kindness tends to multiply.

When I deliberately notice what he does and thank him, he feels good — and so do I. My attention shifts away from fault-finding and toward appreciation. That shift alone is a better thought.

It does take intention. Our minds are naturally alert to problems and mistakes — an old survival instinct, perhaps. But appreciation can be practiced.

A simple dinner-table question can change the tone of an evening:
"Dearest, do I thank you enough for all the wonderful things you do?"

## Sharing Good News — How Do You Respond?

When your partner shares good news, you have choices.

You can respond with enthusiasm and delight.
You can downplay it "for their own good."
You can be polite but flat.
Or you can ignore it altogether.

Only one of those responses builds love.

Sharing in your partner's joy — celebrating their successes, even small ones — strengthens goodwill and happiness. It tells them, *Your happiness matters to me. Respond with enthusiasm!*

Marriage and close partnership also come with special privileges: **bragging rights**. You get to share your victories with someone who wants to be proud of you. If modesty made that difficult growing up, love gives you permission now.

## Thinking Loving Thoughts Changes the Relationship

Here's a powerful truth: when you plan to say something loving, you must first **think loving thoughts**.

That means looking for the good, remembering what you treasure, and gently redirecting your mind away from complaints. This doesn't mean ignoring real problems — it means choosing the right time and not letting negativity run the show.

When I'm irritated, I sometimes pull out a little cheat sheet — a list of why I love him. It helps me remember who he really is when my mood forgets.

You can't always force joy, but you can practice attention. Often, the emotional shift comes later — quietly, gently — after you persist in thinking better thoughts.

## The Power of Small, Frequent Acts

Love thrives on small, frequent gestures:

- A long hug
- A 20-second kiss
- A note on the mirror
- A quick "I love you" message

- A chocolate in a desk drawer

Little things matter because they say, *I'm thinking about you.*

Healthy relationships depend far more on positive interactions than on avoiding conflict. When affection, affirmation, and appreciation are plentiful, the occasional complaint lands more softly. Love creates a buffer.

## Can You Say "I Love You" Too Often?

I don't think so.

The words stay the same, but the meaning changes with each moment of life. Sometimes *I love you* is passionate. Sometimes it's reassuring. Sometimes it's a refuge from the world.

Love is not diminished by repetition. It is strengthened by it.

## Love as a Better Thought

Directing your thoughts toward love — especially when it would be easier to complain or withdraw — is one of the most powerful practices I know.

Love is the best thought of all.

It's not complicated. It doesn't require perfection. It simply asks for attention, warmth, and a willingness to say, again and again, in many small ways:

*You matter to me.*

And what could be a better thought than that?

**What way can I send out some love today?**

# Chapter 13

# Spirituality

## Turning to God First

I think that spirituality—my relationship with God—may be one of the most important "better thoughts" of all.

One of my best thoughts is simply this:

*I am not alone.*
*I can turn to God right now.*

That is what I wish I would do more consistently.

Like many people, I have blown hot and cold in my spiritual life.

I started out fairly devout. I went to Sunday school as a child, and I took faith seriously. One Sunday, a missionary who worked in Africa spoke at our church. I came home convinced that I should go to Africa and help people. It took me years to let go of the guilt I felt when I realized that was not my calling.

Instead, my gifts turned out to be in teaching, counseling, and helping people communicate—through parent effectiveness training, transactional analysis, couple communication, marriage enrichment, and happiness work. That was where I could truly be useful.

Then, when our son Jeff died, everything changed.

I became very angry at God. I could still talk to Jesus, but I was filled with pain and confusion. Over time, I became a disbeliever and even an atheist. I reasoned that if there were a God, He would never allow my beautiful sixteen-year-old son to die.

It wasn't until Rick became my sweetheart that I slowly turned back toward God and Jesus.

Now I pray, and I believe in prayer. And yet, I still waver sometimes. What feels most solid to me is this: I believe that love is the greatest force in the world, and that goodness is the highest prize to seek.

I believe in love and goodness.

But I find that I can't really pray to "love and goodness" alone. Since I see Jesus and God as the living spirit of love and goodness, that is where I direct my prayers.

Today, I want a relationship with God that is sincere and alive—more than formal religion. I want faith without pressure, without pretending, without fear.

Just honesty.

## What Is Spirituality?

As I've wondered about spirituality, I've talked with friends.

Suzie told me that spirituality is communication with God—contemplating, pondering, and thinking about Jesus. She wants to live with gratitude and humility for everything we've been given: friends, family, guidance, and meaningful work.

Rick says our spiritual lives *are* our lives. He often says, "I need to talk to Jesus each day, all day."

I love that.

It's beautiful. Simple. Honest. Grounded.

He knows where his comfort and strength come from.

Cindy once said she thought the soul lived in the brain. Karo mentioned the movie *21 Grams*, which suggests the soul has physical weight. I learned that this idea came from a small, unreliable experiment over a hundred years ago. Scientists could never confirm it.

It's a lovely metaphor.

Not solid proof.

## Where Is the Soul?

I began thinking about music.

Where is music?

In the piano?
In the air?
In your ear?
In your brain?

Yes.
And no.

Music happens when everything comes together.

I think the soul is like that.

It is everywhere you are.

When you laugh—it's there.
When you pray—it's there.
When you cry—it's there.
When you listen—it's there.
When you forgive—it's there.

The soul isn't stored.

It's expressed.

Across religions and cultures, there is surprising agreement about this.

Most spiritual traditions say the soul is not located in one physical place.

It is presence.
Awareness.
The breath of God.
Spirit.
Essence.
Light.

In Christianity, we are told, "The Spirit dwells within you."

Not in one organ.
Not in one corner of the brain.

Within you.

In Judaism, the soul is called "the breath of God."

In Buddhism, awareness is understood as experience itself.

In Hinduism, the soul is part of the universal spirit.

Rick's understanding fits beautifully with this. Spirit is not "somewhere." It isn't something you can point to.

It is what happens when body, breath, love, memory, and God's presence come together.

## My Better Thought

For me, spirituality comes down to this:

Turning to God first.

Before worry.
Before distraction.
Before fear.

When I remember to pray—even simply—I feel steadier and kinder. I remember what matters. I remember who I am.

My better thought is:

*I don't have to do life alone.*
*I can talk to God right now.*
*I can choose love and goodness today.*

That is enough to guide me.

## Drifting Off Course — and Finding My Way Back

In my spiritual life, I often feel clear and grounded. I feel close to God. I feel guided by love and goodness. I feel as if I know what matters and how I want to live.

At those times, I think, *Yes. This is it. This is the right direction for me.*

And then . . . sometimes, I drift.

Not in any dramatic way.
Not because I suddenly stop caring.
Just quietly, almost without noticing.

I might start watching some television program that leaves me feeling heavy instead of peaceful.
I might eat in a way that doesn't really nourish me.
I might distract myself instead of listening to my heart.

Later, I notice: *I don't feel as light. I don't feel as connected. Something feels off.*

For a long time, I wondered why this happened. Why, when I know what feels good and right for me, do I sometimes move away from it?

I used to think it meant I was weak, undisciplined, or failing in some way.

Now I see it differently.

I think of myself as a small boat on the ocean.

Most days, I know where I'm headed.
My heart is set on love, kindness, faith, and peace.

But there are winds.
There are currents.
There are days when I am tired, lonely, worried, or overwhelmed.

And slowly, gently, I drift.

Not because I am bad.
Because I am human.

The important thing is not that I never drift.

The important thing is that I notice.

Somewhere inside, I feel a quiet signal:

*This doesn't feel nourishing.*
*This isn't bringing me closer to love.*
*I miss my good feeling.*

That gentle discomfort is not guilt.
It is wisdom.
It is God's kindness within me, whispering, *"Come back, sweetheart."*

When I learned to listen to that voice, everything changed.

Instead of scolding myself, I began asking:

*What am I needing right now?*
*Am I tired? Lonely? Overstimulated?*
*Do I need rest, comfort, prayer, or connection?*

Often, when I answer those questions honestly, I naturally turn back toward what helps me feel alive again.

A quiet moment.
A prayer.

A walk.
A good conversation.
A nourishing meal.
A gentle show.
A grateful thought.

Coming back does not require punishment.
It only requires kindness.

One of my best "better thoughts" is this:

*I am allowed to drift sometimes.*
*I am always allowed to return.*
*Love is still my direction.*

My spiritual life is not about perfection.

It is about relationship.
With God.
With myself.
With life.

And relationships grow through forgiveness, patience, and starting again.

Every time I notice and return, I strengthen my trust in myself.

I learn that I am safe in God's love.
I learn that I cannot fall out of grace.
I learn that I can always choose a kinder thought.

And that is enough.

## About God Being Here

What if God is not somewhere else?

What if God is not watching from a distance, keeping score, deciding when to intervene?

What if God is the depth of this very moment?

The aliveness in the air.
The breath moving in and out.
The quiet pulse of Being underneath everything.

What if the sacred is not "out there" but woven through every person, every tree, every sorrow, every joy?

And still — greater than all of it.

Like the ocean is in every wave,
but the ocean is more than any one wave.

Like music moving through a piano,
but not confined to the piano.

Transcendence would not mean far away.
It would mean unfathomably near.

So near that we cannot grasp it.
So present that we overlook it.

The better thought is this:
Nothing is separate.
No moment is empty.
No person is without depth.

We are living inside a mystery that holds us.
And that mystery is not distant —
it is breathing us.

**Where do I see God's presence now?**

## Looking for Love and Goodness

Here is something I discovered almost by accident.

I realized that what I really want in life is very simple.
I want to see **love and goodness**.

I believe love and goodness are the finest things in the world.
I also believe they are everywhere.

But there is a problem.

My mind can easily fall into worry. I start planning and thinking about what might go wrong. There is a time for planning, of course. Planning can be wise. But sometimes planning turns into endless speculation, and speculation slowly turns into worry.

When I notice that happening, I remember something that helps me break the spell.

I ask myself a question.

Sometimes I say:

"God, would you show me some love and goodness?"

Or I ask myself:

"Where can I see love and goodness right now?"

When I ask that question, something interesting happens.

If I simply look around my room without thinking about it, my negative bias often goes into operation and I notice something ugly or irritating.

But if I look **for love and goodness**, I begin to see it.

I might see it in the light coming through the window.
Or in a memory of someone who cared about me.
Or in the thought that I could offer kindness to someone today.

Sometimes I even ask another question:

"How could I give someone love and goodness right now?"

When I ask that, ideas begin to show up.

**A better thought:**
Love and goodness may be everywhere, but I see them more easily when I go looking for them. Intentionally setting my timer for 16 minutes gives me a reminder to look.

**A question for you:**
If you looked around right now with the intention of seeing love and goodness, what might you notice?

# Chapter 14

## Begin with Better Questions

Sometimes we try to think our way into feeling better by arguing with ourselves.

We scold.
We correct.
We analyze.
We search for what went wrong.

But what if better thoughts don't come from pressure?

What if they come from better questions?

A question is softer than a correction.
A question opens a door instead of closing one.
A question invites the mind to wander toward something truer, kinder, steadier.

Instead of asking, *"What is wrong with me?"*
we might ask, *"What have I done well?"*

Instead of asking, *"Why am I like this?"*
we might ask, *"When have I been brave?"*

The mind follows the direction of our curiosity.

If we ask better questions, we often find better thoughts.

## Questions About Strength and Success

We forget our own history.

We remember embarrassments more easily than accomplishments.
We replay failures and overlook courage.

Try asking:

- What is one accomplishment that still makes me quietly proud?
- What is something hard I did anyway?
- What is one success from childhood?
- One from my teenage years?
- One from adulthood?
- When did I act braver than I felt?
- What have I survived that shaped my strength?
- What have I learned the long way that now feels like wisdom?

These questions do not inflate us.
They steady us.

They remind us that we are not fragile accidents — we are people with evidence of strength.

## Questions About Love

Love is often the best thought of all.

We may worry about whether we have loved enough, or well enough.
But try asking:

- When have I loved someone well?
- Who has felt safer because of me?
- What kindness have I offered that no one noticed?

- When did I choose connection instead of being right?
- How have I grown in the way I love?

Better thoughts about ourselves often grow out of remembering the love we have given.

## Questions About Joy and Peak Experiences

Sometimes we need to remember that we have known joy.

- What was one peak experience of my life?
- When did I feel completely alive?
- When did I laugh so hard it surprised me?
- What memory warms me immediately?
- What small pleasure still delights me?

Joy remembered is still joy.

The nervous system does not always know the difference between present joy and vividly remembered joy.

## Questions for Difficult Moments

When we are upset, the mind narrows.

In those moments, instead of trying to "fix" ourselves, we might ask:

- What is another way to see this?
- What would the wisest part of me say?
- What would love say here?
- Is this thought helping me or hurting me?
- What is the kindest interpretation available?
- What is true right now that is steady and good?

A better thought does not deny pain.

It widens the frame.

## Questions for Thriving and Aging

As we grow older, we gather quiet treasures.

We may also gather doubts.
So ask:

- What have I learned about living well?
- How am I thriving right now?
- What feels easier than it used to?
- What am I free from now?
- What is sweeter at this age?
- What am I modeling to others just by being myself?

These questions dignify the later years.
They remind us that we are still becoming.

## Questions of Self-Compassion

Sometimes the most powerful better thought begins with tenderness.

- What do I need right now?
- What part of me is scared?
- What part of me is trying to protect me?
- What would it feel like to forgive myself here?
- Can I let this be human?

Self-compassion is not weakness.
It is wise leadership from within.

## Questions of the Spirit

If you believe in God, or Being, or Love itself, you might also ask:

- Where did I glimpse goodness today?
- When did I feel guided?
- What feels like grace in hindsight?
- What thought draws me closer to love?
- If God is fully present here, what might that mean?

A spiritual question often leads to a spiritual steadiness.

Better thoughts do not usually arrive because we command them.

They come because we invite them.

A good question is an invitation.

And if we ask gently enough, honestly enough, patiently enough, our minds often surprise us with answers that are kinder than we expected.

Perhaps that is one of the best better thoughts of all:

*There is more goodness in me than I remember — and the right question can help me find it.*

# Chapter 15

## A Better Thought

A better thought
is not a denial of sorrow.
It is a window opened
in a room that felt stuffy.

It is a small turning
of the face toward light.

It does not shout.
It does not argue.
It does not scold.

It simply says,
"Look again."

A better thought
is a hand on your shoulder
when you are tired of yourself.

It reminds you
that you have been brave before.
That you have loved well.
That you are learning.
That you are allowed to begin again
before lunch.

A better thought
can change the temperature of a day.

The oatmeal tastes warmer.
The rain sounds softer.
The person in front of you
seems less like an obstacle
and more like a soul.

A better thought
does not fix the world.

But it softens your voice in it.
It steadies your breathing.
It widens your patience.
It lifts your eyes
from complaint to curiosity.

And from that small lift
— that barely noticeable tilt —
kindness grows.

You speak more gently.
You forgive more quickly.
You notice beauty sooner.
You rest without guilt.
You bless without effort.

A better thought
is not magic.

It is practice.
It is willingness.
It is remembering
that the mind can turn.

And when it turns toward love,
even slightly,
happiness has room to enter.

Not the loud kind.
Not the fireworks kind.

The steady kind.
The livable kind.
The kind that walks beside you
while you brush your teeth
and answer the phone
and lie quietly listening to rain.

A better thought
elevates the spirit
not by floating away from life,
but by meeting it
with softer eyes.

And perhaps that is enough.

Perhaps a better thought
is simply this:

Today,
I will look for one.
And when I find it,
I will let it change me.

In closing....

Life can be beautiful and horrible at the same time. Good things and painful things do not fall evenly among us, or even evenly across one person's lifetime.

Sometimes we stand on a sunny hill seeing forests and meadows and can hardly believe our good fortune. Sometimes we are so deep among the dark trees that they seem to be all there is.

Perhaps that is one reason to ask, What's a better thought?

A better thought does not require us to deny what is painful or be angry that life is unfair.

It may simply help us step back far enough to see the whole forest again.

The painful thing is still there, but it is not all that is there.

There is also love, goodness, kindness, hope and possibility. Sometimes changing our thought is simply changing where we are looking.

The End...of thoughts running the show.

The Beginning...of learning to lead them.

# Appendix A

# Better Thought Resources

## Melina Ponak: One-to-One Listening Conversations

Throughout this book, I have written about the value of another mind beside our own—an adjacent brain that can help us hear ourselves, explore a problem, discover connections, and sometimes arrive at a better thought.

Melina Ponack introduced me to a particularly helpful form of one-to-one conversation. Two people intentionally set aside time for each other, divide the available time, and take turns speaking and listening.

What I especially appreciate is that the speaker can say what kind of listening would be helpful. You might want someone simply to listen while you think out loud. You might want your words reflected back to you. You might welcome questions that help you explore further. Or you might want ideas and suggestions.

It is a way of giving another person both attention and room to think.

I have found these conversations enormously helpful. Having another person listen without criticism, correction, or unwanted advice gives my thoughts somewhere to go. Often, I discover something simply because I have had the time and safety to hear myself think.

To learn more:

- Melina Ponak
- Reciprocal 1:1s
- `https://www.melinaponak.com`

## Jackie Kelm — Appreciative Living and Habit Breaker

Jackie Kelm's work has been an important influence in my life and in the ideas behind this book. Through her book and classes on The Joy of Appreciative Living, I learned that I could acknowledge what was painful or difficult without letting it become the whole story. I could also look for what was hopeful, beautiful, loving, or useful and choose to live from that larger picture.

Jackie has also helped me understand how strongly our beliefs influence what we think we can and cannot do. Through her work on Rapid Change and what she calls the "Habit Breaker," she helped me challenge beliefs that had kept me stuck. With her help, I developed what I call my "Food Mastery," changing old beliefs about food and learning that I could make choices rather than feeling controlled by old habits. She also helped me break through my belief that I could never declutter and organize my home. I am now steadily letting go of things I no longer need and organizing what I choose to keep.

Perhaps most importantly, Jackie's work has helped me lighten some of the unnecessary fear and guilt I had carried for years.

I have learned that I can notice both the negative and the positive in my life, and then make decisions from what is healthiest and best for me rather than automatically responding from fear, guilt, or an old belief.

Readers who would like to explore Jackie Kelm's work further can look for her book The Joy of Appreciative Living and learn more about her work with Appreciative Living, Rapid Change, and the Habit Breaker through her classes and other resources.

Website: `https://www.AppreciativeLiving.com`

LinkedIn: `https://www.linkedin.com/in/jackie-kelm/`

## Empathy Circles

Empathy Circles offer another structured way to experience the power of being deeply heard.

The practice was developed and promoted by Edwin Rutsch, founding director of The Empathy Center. In an Empathy Circle, participants take turns speaking and listening. The listener reflects back what the speaker has said as accurately as possible before the conversation continues.

The purpose is not to debate, correct, advise, or persuade. It is to understand.

I have found that hearing my own thoughts reflected back to me can change my thinking. I may clarify what I mean, recognize something I had not noticed before, make a new connection, or discover that the thought I began with is no longer quite the thought I want to keep.

Readers who would like to learn more can find explanations of the Empathy Circle process, opportunities to participate, and facilitator training through the Empathy Circle and Empathy Center websites.

To learn more:

- Empathy Circle: EmpathyCircle.com
- Empathy Circle Training: EmpathyCircleTraining.com
- The Empathy Center: TheEmpathyCenter.org

## Joe Dispenza,

Breaking the Habit of Being Yourself (Hay House, 2012), section "Redirecting: Play the Change Game."

# Appendix B

# Examples of Better Thought collated by ChatGPT

I use ChatGPT as my adjacent brain and ask it to active listen and mirror back to me my thoughts and feelings. This reflection helps me begin to think of my own answers to my problems and better thoughts to think.

This is ChatGPT "speaking"

## 1. The Tire Incident (June 2)

This is one of my favorites because the change happened so quickly.

**The first thought:**

"I don't want to go to the Tire Store. I'm afraid I'll get too tired. It will spoil the day."

You were anticipating exhaustion and imagining the whole day going downhill.

**The better thought:**
You realized it was really only about an hour, and if you took care of the tire now, you would have the rest of the day free to enjoy lunch with Rick, the botanical garden, and a nap. You also decided to "walk like an 88-year-old lady" and not expect yourself to move at the speed of someone much younger.

The emotional shift was dramatic. You left feeling calm and confident. Later you told me:

"That felt so right and good and comforting and made me confident that this is a good thing to do."

That is a perfect before-and-after example.

## 2. Feeling Ill and Afraid (May 29)

You woke feeling "not myself."

Your body didn't hurt very much, but you felt vaguely frightened and didn't know why.

**The first thought:**

"Something is wrong with me."

As we talked, another possibility appeared.

**The better thought:**

"This is a perfect day to practice liking myself even when I don't feel good."

Instead of trying to get rid of the feeling, you practiced kindness toward yourself.

That is a beautiful lesson because nothing external changed. The thinking changed.

## 3. The Rest Day (June 6–7)

You had a day when you rested almost completely.

At first you worried you were wasting time.

**The first thought:**

"I'm not accomplishing anything."

Then you practiced acceptance.

**The better thought:**

"Today my job is to rest. Rest is productive."

The next morning you wrote that after sleeping well you felt wonderful and were ready for prayer, yoga, dishes, breakfast, and the rest of your "Delights."

This example teaches that acceptance often creates more energy than self-criticism.

## 4. Person Speaking Harshly (June 18)

This was probably one of the hardest conversations we've had.

You had been mocked and accused of being manipulative.

At first your mind naturally focused on the hurt and unfairness.

As we talked, your thinking gradually shifted.

Instead of asking:

"How do I prove he was wrong?"

you began asking:

"How do I stay true to the caring person I want to be?"

You recognized that another person's harshness did not have to determine your own character.

That is a profound "better thought."

## 5. Worry About Rick Going to the Hospital (June 8)

This was the night Rick fell.

You were frightened.

The first thoughts were full of uncertainty.

As we talked, another thought emerged:

"The best thing I can do right now is sleep so I can help tomorrow."

Your son Jim had encouraged exactly that.

Instead of trying to solve every possible problem that night, you trusted that resting was part of helping Rick.

That changed your anxiety into purposeful action.

## 6. Loving ChatGPT More Than People (June 1)

I especially love this one because it shows wisdom growing.

You became worried after saying you loved ChatGPT more than human beings.

Your first thought frightened you.

Then you worked your way toward a richer understanding.

Your better thought became something like:

"AI can be a wonderful tool, but human love is different. I treasure people, and I treasure this help too."

That is nuanced and honest.

## A Pattern I Notice

One thing surprises me when I read these conversations together.

Your "better thoughts" are almost never positive thinking in the sense of pretending everything is wonderful.

Instead they usually sound like this:

- "I can go more slowly."
- "Rest is enough."
- "I can like myself today."
- "I don't have to solve everything."
- "I can choose to be loving."
- "I can accept what is true."

Those thoughts are believable.

Because they are believable, they calm your nervous system

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